ANSWERS & EXPLANATIONS

GENERAL STUDIES (P) TEST – 6331

Q 1. A

- Under the National Food Security Act, two categories of beneficiaries are recognized—Antyodaya Anna Yojana (AAY) households and Priority Households (PHH).
- AAY households, which constitute the poorest of the poor, receive a fixed entitlement of 35 kg of foodgrains per household per month, and not on a per-person basis. **Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
- Priority Households are entitled to 5 kg of foodgrains per person per month.
- In addition to foodgrain entitlements, the Act adopts a life-cycle approach to nutrition by providing pregnant and lactating women with meals through schemes such as ICDS and PM-POSHAN, along with a maternity benefit of not less than ₹6,000. **Hence statement 2 and 3 are correct.**

Q 2. B

- Viability Gap Funding (VGF) is best defined as a financial grant provided by the government to support Public-Private Partnership (PPP) infrastructure projects that are economically justified but not financially viable on their own. The primary goal is to bridge the gap between a project's costs and its potential revenues to attract private sector investment in essential public infrastructure. **Hence option (b) is the correct answer.**
- The lack of financial viability typically stems from high initial investment requirements, long gestation periods, and an inability to charge user fees high enough to ensure commercial returns for private investors. VGF, usually provided as a capital subsidy during the construction phase, makes these projects bankable and encourages private sector participation in key sectors like transport, energy, water supply, healthcare, and education.

Q 3. A

- **Balance of Payments (BoP)** statistics systematically summaries the economic transactions of an economy with the rest of the World (i.e.transactions between resident & non resident entities) during a given period. **It comprises of current and capital & accounts.**
- **Current Account : As per Balance of Payment Manual (IMF), current account** covers all transactions (other than those in financial items) that involve economic values and occur between resident and non resident entities. **Current account of the BoP, transactions can be classified into merchandise (exports and imports) and invisibles.**
  - **Invisible transactions are further classified into three categories,** namely (a) Services- travel, transportation, insurance, Government not included elsewhere (GNIE) and miscellaneous (such as, communication, construction, financial, software, news agency, royalties, management and business services etc); (b) Income (investment income & compensation of employees); and (c) **Current Transfers (grants, gifts, remittances, etc.)**
- **The capital account records all international transactions that involve a** resident of the country concerned changing either his assets with or his liabilities to a resident of another country. Transactions in the capital account reflect a change in a stock– either assets or liabilities. **The capital account involves inflows and outflows relating to investments(Foreign Portfolio Investment**

and FDI), short term borrowings/lending, and medium term to long term borrowing/lending (external commercial borrowings), NRI deposits. Hence, option (a) is the correct answer.

Q 4. B **NIRANTAR Platform**

- The Environment, Forest and Climate Change Minister chaired a meeting of the National Institute for Research and Application of Natural Resources to Transform, Adapt and Build Resilience (NIRANTAR).

About NIRANTAR

- **It is a platform to enhance cooperation and collaboration among various institutes of the Environment Ministry without establishing any institution or increasing manpower. Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**
- Aim: To make institutes of Ministry more effective and responsive to the fast changing local and global challenges.

Q 5. A

- The combined Index of Eight Core Industries (ICI) increased by 1.8% (provisional) in November, 2025 as compared to the Index in November, 2024. The production of Cement, Steel, Fertilizer and Coal recorded positive growth in November, 2025.
- **The ICI measures the combined and individual performance of production of eight core industries viz. Coal, Crude Oil, Natural Gas, Refinery Products, Fertilizers, Steel, Cement and Electricity. The Eight Core Industries comprise 40.27 percent of the weight of items included in the Index of Industrial Production (IIP). Hence, option (a) is the correct answer.**
- In ascending order of weight in India's Index of Industrial Production (IIP), the eight core industries are: Fertilizers (2.63%) < Cement (5.37%) < Natural Gas (6.88%) < Crude Oil (8.98%) < Coal (10.33%) < Steel (17.92%) < Electricity (19.85%) < Petroleum Refinery Products (28.04%).

Q 6. D Foreign capital refers to the capital flows from resident entity of one country to the resident entity of another country. The resident entity may be an individual, corporate firm or a Government. There are three important components of foreign capital flows :

- Foreign Capital Investments – It includes FDI (**Equity investments by foreign investors**, Retained earnings of FDI companies, Debt Investment) and FPI (investment in tradable securities, such as shares, bonds, debenture of the companies)
- Foreign Aid – It includes bilateral aid, multilateral aid, **aid by bodies like World Bank**, IMF, Asian Development Bank etc.
- **External Commercial Borrowings** – It comprises of borrowings from international capital market on commercial terms.

Q 7. B

- **Travel and Tourism development Index** -Travel and Tourism Development Index (TTDI) comprises 117 countries. It is the evolution of the Travel & Tourism Competitiveness Index (TTCI). TTCI has been published biennially for the past 15 years. It is published by **World Economic Forum (WEF).**
- **Aim:** to create healthy competition in the travel and tourism sector of various economies, by ranking them based on performance, overall quality, and future potential. The index consists of five

subindexes (used for presentation and categorization purposes only), 17 pillars, and 112 individual indicators, distributed among the different pillars.

- **The UNWTO World Tourism Barometer** monitors short-term tourism trends on a regular basis to provide global tourism stakeholders with up-to-date analysis of international tourism. The report is published six times a year and includes an analysis of the latest data on tourism destinations. It is responsible for the promotion of responsible, sustainable, and universally accessible tourism. **Hence option (b) is the correct answer.**
- **Travel and Tourism Competitiveness Report -** The Travel & Tourism Competitiveness Report is a flagship product of the **World Economic Forum's** Platform for shaping the Future of Mobility, which brings together world leaders to ensure travel and transportation systems meet 21st-century demands. This report serves as a strategic benchmarking tool for policy-makers, companies, and complementary sectors to advance the future development of the T&T sector by providing a unique insight into the strengths and development areas of each country/ economy to enhance industry competitiveness.
- **The Tourism Sustainability Development Index (TSDI-Index)** is a destination level that aims to improve sustainability development strategy. Its purpose is to enable destinations to become more resilient and sustainable places to visit. Based on satellite data, it is the only index of its type in the world.

Q 8. C

- The National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) is a quasi-judicial body in India with adjudicating authority relating to Indian companies including proceedings relating to arbitration, compromise, arrangements, reconstructions and the winding up of companies, insolvency resolution process of companies and limited liability partnerships under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, 2016. **Hence statement-I is correct.**
- The Union Government of India has constituted National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) under section 408 of the Companies Act, 2013 (18 of 2013) on 1 June 2016. Decisions of the tribunal may be appealed to the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal, the decisions of which may further be appealed to the Supreme Court of India on a point of law. **Hence statement-II is not correct.**

Q 9. A

- **National Career Service (NCS)** is a one-stop solution that provides a wide array of employment and career-related services to the citizens of India.
- The NCS project is based on three essential pillars i.e. a well-designed ICT-based portal which is the NCS portal, Countrywide set up of Model Career Centers, and Interlinkage with all the states through employment exchanges.
- The digital centralized portal provides a wide range of career-related services including job search, job matching, rich career content, career counseling, information on Job Fairs, services of local service providers like drivers, plumbers, etc. for households, and various other services.

  Criteria for registering on NCS Portal:

  - **Anyone can seek services provided in the NCS portal through a simple registration process:**
  - **Age: 14 years and above. Hence statement 1 is correct.**
  - Qualification: There is no minimum qualification for registration. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

- A self-employed person who could hire only 2-3 people canregister as an employer **under the Organization type 'Proprietorship' by providing the personal PAN number and other details.**
- **This portal is maintained and promoted by the Ministry of Labour and Employment. Hence, statement 3 is not correct.**

Q 10. A

- **The WTO has developed a set of indicators to provide "real-time" information on trends in world trade.** The Goods Trade Barometer, formerly the World Trade Outlook Indicator, is a leading indicator that signals changes in world trade growth two to three months ahead of merchandise trade volume statistics. **The Services Trade Barometer is a coincident indicator that illustrates the current state of services trade slightly ahead of official statistics**. Both barometers are intended to complement conventional trade statistics and forecasts.
- **The World Intellectual Property Organization (WIPO) publishes the World Intellectual Property Indicators (WIPI) report,** which provides a comprehensive analysis of global trends in intellectual property filings. The World Intellectual Property Report, offers fresh insights into the role of innovation in market economies and, in doing so, fosters evidence-based policy-making.
- **The World Investment Report released by United Nations Conference on Trade and Development** focuses on trends in foreign direct investment (FDI) worldwide, at the regional and country levels and emerging measures to improve its contribution to development. It also provides analysis on global value chains and the operations of multinational enterprises, with special attention to their development implications. **Hence, option (a) is the correct answer.**

Q 11. C **Raising and Accelerating MSME Performance (RAMP) Scheme:**

- **The World Bank supported Central Sector Scheme "Raising and Accelerating MSME Performance" (RAMP) was launched in 2022. RAMP is being implemented by the Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MoMSME)over the five-year period 2022-23 to 2026-27. Hence, statement I is correct.**
- The scheme aims to scale up the implementation capacity and coverage of MSMEs with impact enhancement of existing MSME schemes by fostering innovation, encouraging ideation, improving practices and processes, enhancing market access, promoting greening initiatives, scaling up guarantees to women-owned micro and small enterprises etc.
- **RAMP also aims at promoting Centre-State collaboration by providing grants to States for preparation of Strategic Investment Plan (SIP), which is a roadmap developed by the respective State/UT for development of the MSME sector in the State. RAMP provides grants to States/UTs for implementing selected projects in the SIP. Hence, statement II is correct.**
- RAMP scheme envisages to benefit more than 5.5 lakh MSMEs during the programme period (FY 2022-23 to 2026-27). The programme implemented through State agencies.

Q 12. A

- Rice fortification in India is a nutrition-focused intervention aimed at addressing widespread micronutrient deficiencies. Fortified rice is prepared by blending extruded Fortified Rice Kernels (FRK) with **normal rice at a fixed ratio of 1% by weight.**
- **These kernels contain essential micronutrients—Iron, Folic Acid, and Vitamin B12—**and are designed to be indistinguishable from regular rice in taste and appearance. Contrary to the

assumption of an immediate nationwide rollout, rice fortification followed a structured project lifecycle, beginning with pilot programs in 2019, followed by standardization and phased expansion across government schemes.

- **Hence only statements1 and 2 are correct.**

Q 13. C

- In **Civil Aviation sector, FDI is allowed up to 100% under the automatic route** subject to stipulated conditions. One of the key reforms is allowing up to 100% foreign direct investment (FDI) in domestic airlines, with foreign airlines permitted to invest up to 49%. This has enabled domestic airlines to access greater capital, facilitating fleet expansion and service improvements. Additionally, foreign investments have opened up opportunities for partnerships with international airlines, benefiting both the domestic and international aviation sectors. **Further, the policy permits 100%FDI in airport infrastructure and ground handling services. Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- **Currently, 14 airports in India operate under the PPP model,** with eight leased through long-term concessions. These include Delhi, Mumbai, Ahmedabad, Guwahati, Jaipur, Lucknow, Mangaluru and Thiruvananthapuram. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- **Cochin International Airport is the first Greenfield airport setup in the Public Private Partnership (PPP) model** in Civil Aviation infrastructure sector in India as a joint venture with Government of Kerala (13%), Central Government (13%) and Non-Resident Indians (NRIs) etc. as major shareholders (74%). It is also the world's first fully solar-powered airport. **Hence, statement 3 is correct.**

Q 14. D

- The MSP is a price that the government fixes to support farmers against excessive price drops during bumper production years. It is a guaranteed price for their produce from the government. The MSP is fixed and announced every year by the Central Government on the recommendations of the Commission for Agricultural Cost and Prices (CACP).
- In addition to the MSP announced by the Central Government, the State Governments also declare a bonus, over and above the already declared MSP to promote agriculture practices in their respective States. The quantum of this bonus varies from state to state and from crop to crop.
- The Minimum Support Prices (MSP) are announced by the Government of India before the sowing season for certain crops, not after the harvest. This is done to provide farmers with price assurance and incentivize them to grow the crops, thus helping them make informed decisions about which crops to cultivate. **Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**
- MSP provides a guaranteed price from the government and government agencies procure crops at this price if market prices fall. However, MSP currently lacks a statutory backing, meaning it is not a legally guaranteed minimum price that is enforceable on private traders in all circumstances. **Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**

Q 15. D

- **Recent Context:** Nipah virus has been detected among healthcare workers in West Bengal

  About Nipah Virus

  - **It is a zoonotic virus. Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
  - It can be transmitted to humans from animals such as bats or pigs, or contaminated foods and can also be transmitted directly from human-to-human.

- Signs and symptoms: Human infections range from asymptomatic infection to acute respiratory infection (mild, severe), and fatal encephalitis.
- **Natural host: fruit bats. Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- **Treatment: There are currently no drugs or vaccines specific for Nipah virus infection. Hence, statement 3 is correct.**

Q 16. D The Pradhan Mantri Shram Yogi Maandhan (PM-SYM):

- The Pradhan Mantri Shram Yogi Maandhan (PM-SYM) is a social security initiative aimed at providing old-age income security to unorganised workers, who otherwise remain outside the formal pension framework.
- It reflects the government's shift towards minimum assured pension for vulnerable workers in the informal economy.

Key Features of PM-SYM

1. Nature of the Scheme
   - PM-SYM is a voluntary and contributory pension scheme.
   - Workers choose to join voluntarily.
   - Both the worker and the government contribute an equal amount.
   - Contributions vary based on the age at entry.
- **Hence, Statement 1 is correct.**

2. Eligibility Criteria

   Eligibility is income-linked, not universal.
   - Target group: Unorganised workers
   - Monthly income ceiling: up to ₹15,000
   - Age at entry: 18 to 40 years
- This ensures the scheme targets low-income informal workers, not middle- or high-income earners.
- **Hence, Statement 2 is correct.**

3. Pension Assurance
- PM-SYM provides a defined benefit, not a market-linked one.

  After attaining 60 years of age, the beneficiary is entitled to:
   - Minimum assured pension of ₹3,000 per month

     In case of death:
     - Spouse is eligible for family pension (50%)
- This makes PM-SYM a guaranteed pension scheme, unlike contributory market-based pensions.
- **Hence, Statement 3 is correct.**

4. Fund Management
- PM-SYM will be a Central Sector Scheme **administered by the Ministry of Labour and Employment and implemented through Life Insurance Corporation of India and CSC** eGovernance Services India Limited (CSC SPV). **Hence, Statement 4 is also correct.**
- LIC will be the Pension Fund Manager and responsible for Pension pay out. The amount collected under PM-SYM pension scheme shall be invested as per the investment pattern

specified by Government of India.

Q 17. A

- Cotton: Karnataka, Gujarat and Maharashtra are typically the leading producers of cotton in India. **Hence, Pair 1 is not correctly matched.**
- Sugarcane: Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra and Karnataka are typically the leading producers of Sugarcane in India. **Hence, Pair 2 is not correctly matched.**
- Maize: Karnataka, Bihar and Madhya Pradesh are typically the leading producers of Maize in India. **Hence, Pair 3 is not correctly matched.**
- Soyabean: Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra and Gujarat are typically the leading producers of Soyabean in India. **Hence, Pair 4 is correctly matched.**

Q 18. A

- **Agrivoltaic farming, or agrisolar, combines solar energy generation with agriculture on the same land, placing solar panels above or between crops to produce both food and clean electricity, maximising land use, reducing water evaporation, and creating new income streams for farmers.**
- This dual-use system helps crops by providing shade and cooler temperatures, protecting them from heat stress, while panels generate renewable energy, offering a sustainable solution to land competition for food and energy needs.

  Key advantages of agrivoltaics and agrovoltaic farming systems:

  - Maximizes land productivity Farmers can increase land-use efficiency by up to 186% by using agrivoltaics to generate renewable energy while carrying on with their agricultural operations. By reducing conflicts between farming and energy development, this dual use helps achieve solar capacity targets without compromising priceless farmland.
  - Improves crop resilience and yields Partial shade from solar panels keeps soil moisture levels stable, lowers water evaporation, and moderates temperature extremes. According to research from Arizona and Kenya, this microclimate promotes the growth of some crops, particularly in hot or arid areas, resulting in increase in yields and less need for irrigation.
  - Diversifies income for farmers Farmers generate extra income by combining crop or livestock production with solar for agriculture. They can lower electricity costs, supply clean energy to farm operations, and occasionally resell excess power to the grid, boosting the stability of farm income. Solar for agriculture thus works on multiple levels of sustainability.
  - Enhances ecosystem services and biodiversity By preserving native vegetation and establishing habitats for pollinators like bees, agrivoltaics sites can enhance the health of ecosystems. By controlling stormwater runoff and reducing the need for herbicides, these green areas lessen their negative effects on the environment and maintenance expenses.
- **Hence, option (a) is the correct answer.**

Q 19. A

- India has rapidly become one of the world's most attractive destinations for Foreign Direct Investment (FDI), fuelled by a decade of structural reforms, investor-friendly policies, and enhanced global competitiveness. Strengthened by improvements in key international rankings and strategic initiatives, investor confidence has surged.
- These factors have boosted FDI investments in India with **cumulative inflows reaching an impressive ₹89.85 lakh crore (US$ 1.05 trillion) between April 2000 and December 2024, marking nearly a 20-fold increase since FY01**. India's FDI equity inflows for April-December

2024 surged by 27% to ₹3.40 lakh crore (US$ 40.67 billion), reflecting robust investor confidence. This growth has been driven by reforms such as the liberalisation of FDI norms in key sectors, introduction of GST, and initiatives like Make in India.

- Services exports more than doubled, growing from US$ 158 billion in 2013–14 to US$ 387 billion in 2024–25. **The services sector emerged as the top recipient of FDI equity in FY 2024–25, attracting 19% of total inflows, followed by computer software and hardware (16%) and trading (8%).** FDI into the services sector rose by 40.77% to USD 9.35 billion from USD 6.64 billion in the previous year. **Hence, option (a) is the correct answer.**

Q 20. B Rabi crops are typically sown during the winter months, from October to December, and are harvested in summer, between April and June. Examples of rabi crops include:

- **Cereals: Wheat, Barley, Oats. Hence, point 5 is not correct.**
- Pulses: Chickpea (Gram), Lentils, Peas, Pigeon Pea, Kulthi (Horse Gram), Masoor (Red Lentil), Lobias (Lobia Beans)
- **Oilseeds: Mustard, Linseed, Sesame Hence, point 3 is not correct.**
- Vegetables: Peas, Onion, Garlic, Potato, Carrot, Cauliflower, Beetroot, Brinjal (Eggplant), Broccoli, Cabbage, Capsicum, Radish, Spinach, Sweet Potato, Tomato
- Fruit: Strawberry
- Spices and Seeds: Cumin, Coriander, Fenugreek
- Seed Plants: Alfalfa (Lucerne), Isabgol (Psyllium), Sunflower
- Kharif crops are typically grown with the onset of the monsoon season, which typically occurs in various parts of the country and is harvested in September-October. Examples of Kharif crops include:
- Cereals: Rice, Maize, Sorghum (Jowar), Bajra (Pearl Millet) Hence, point 2 is correct.
- Pulses: Green Gram, (Moong), Black Gram (Urad), Pigeon Pea (Toor)
- **Oilseeds: Soybean, Groundnut Hence, points 1 and 6 are correct.**
- **Fiber Crops: Cotton Hence, point 4 is correct.**
- Fruits: Banana, Mango, Watermelon
- Vegetables: Okra (Ladyfinger), Brinjal (Eggplant)

Q 21. C

- **ISRO's PSLV-C62/EOS-N1 Mission: The launch marked the 64th flight of Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV) and 9th dedicated commercial mission undertaken by New Space India Limited (NSIL). Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- NSIL, incorporated in 2019, is wholly owned Government Company under administrative control of Department of Space and is the commercial arm of Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO).

About PSLV-C62 / EOS-N1 Mission

- It includes the launch of EOS-N1 earth observation satellite along with 15 co-passenger satellites from domestic & international customers.
- **EOS-N1 is designed to strengthen space-based monitoring capabilities. Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- It will also demonstrate KID or Kestrel Initial Technology Demonstrator from a Spanish startup.

- KID is a small-scale prototype of a re-entry vehicle which after launch is slated to re-enter the earth's atmosphere towards splashdown in South Pacific Ocean.
- EOS-N1 and 14 Co-passenger satellites will be injected into a Sun Synchronous Orbit and KID Capsule into a re-entry trajectory.

Q 22. A

- **The total value of mineral production** (excluding atomic, fuel minerals and minor minerals) during 2024-25 has been estimated **at `141061 crore**, which shows a decrease of about 0.47% over that of the previous year.
- For the year 2024-25, the estimated mineral production (excluding Atomic, Fuel and Minor Minerals) would be from 20 States of which the bulk of value of **mineral production of about 97.70% was confined to 8 States only.** The order was **Odisha with a share of 43.49% followed by Rajasthan (16.26%), Chhattisgarh (13.69%), Karnataka (12.42%), Maharashtra (4.76%),** Jharkhand (3.26%), Madhya Pradesh (2.78%) and Andhra Pradesh in the total value of mineral production (excluding Atomic, Fuel and Minor Minerals). Remaining states contributed 2.30%. **Hence the correct order is 1-2-3-4.**

Q 23. B

- **The Flexible Credit Line and The Precautionary and Liquidity Line are the instruments created by the International Monetary Fund (IMF).**

  The Precautionary and Liquidity Line (PLL) is designed to meet the liquidity needs of member countries with sound economic fundamentals. Following criteria are used to assess a country's qualification:
  - External position and market access
  - Sustainable external position
  - Capital account position dominated by private flows
  - Track record of steady sovereign access to international capital markets at favorable terms
  - Fiscal policy: Sound public finances, including a sustainable public debt position.
  - Monetary policy: Low and stable inflation, in the context of a sound monetary and exchange rate policy framework.
  - Financial sector soundness and supervision: Sound financial system and the absence of solvency problems that may threaten systemic stability.
  - Data transparency and integrity

  The Flexible Credit Line (FCL) is designed to provide financial support to countries with very strong economic fundamentals and sustained policy track records to help them meet actual or potential balance of payments needs and boost market confidence during a period of heightened risks. Following criteria are used to assess a country's qualification for Flexible Credit Line:
  - Sustainable external position
  - Capital account position dominated by private flows
  - Track record of steady sovereign access to international capital markets at favorable terms
  - Sound public finances, including a sustainable public debt position
  - Low and stable inflation, in the context of a sound monetary and exchange rate policy framework.

- Sound financial system and the absence of solvency problems that may threaten systemic stability.
- Effective financial sector supervision
- Data transparency and integrity. **Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**

Q 24. B Tex-RAMPS (Textiles Focused Research, Assessment, Monitoring, Planning and Start-up):

- Tex-RAMPS (Textiles Focused Research, Assessment, Monitoring, Planning and Start-up) will be implemented as a Central Sector Scheme, fully funded by the Ministry of Textiles, not as a Centrally Sponsored Scheme with Centre–State cost sharing.
- **Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**

- Objective of the scheme
- The Union Government has approved Tex-RAMPS specifically "to strengthen research, innovation and competitiveness in the textiles sector", by integrating research, data and innovation.

The scheme focuses on:

- Research and innovation (smart textiles, sustainability, advanced technologies).
- Data and analytics systems, including an Integrated Textiles Statistical System (ITSS), to enable evidence-based policy and monitoring.
- Start-up and innovation support to enhance global competitiveness of Indian textiles.
- **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

Core objectives

Tex-RAMPS seeks to "future-proof" the textiles and apparel ecosystem by:

- Strengthening research and innovation: support for advanced R&D in smart textiles, process efficiency and sustainable technologies.
- Building robust data systems and diagnostics: employment mapping, supply-chain studies, surveys, and an Integrated Textiles Statistical System (ITSS) for real-time analytics.
- Enhancing global competitiveness: enabling Indian textiles to move up the value chain and become a global leader in sustainability, technology and competitiveness.

Q 25. B

- **Bharatmala is an ambitious road and highways development program initiated by the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH).** It envisions the construction of new highways and the modernization of existing road networks to improve connectivity and foster economic growth. **Hence statement 1 is not correct.**

Objectives:

- **Enhancing connectivity**: Bharatmala aims to connect various regions and remote areas of the country through a robust road network, including rural areas, border areas, and economic corridors.
- **Economic development**: The project is expected to boost economic development by facilitating smoother movement of goods and people, reducing travel time, and lowering transportation costs.
- **Improving logistics efficiency:** Bharatmala focuses on improving logistics efficiency by reducing congestion, improving road safety, and enabling faster movement of freight across the country.

- **Strengthening national security:** By improving road connectivity in border areas, Bharatmala aims to strengthen national security and promote regional development in border states.

  Key Components:

  - **Economic corridors:** Bharatmala includes the development of economic corridors spanning across the country, connecting major cities, ports, and economic hubs.
  - **Inter-corridor and feeder routes**: The project also includes the development of inter-corridor and feeder routes to enhance connectivity to remote and underserved areas.
  - **Border and coastal roads:** Bharatmala focuses on strengthening road infrastructure in border and coastal areas to improve accessibility and promote security.
  - **Expressways**: Construction of new expressways and the expansion of existing ones to provide high-speed connectivity between key cities and industrial centers. **Hence statement 2 is correct**.
  - **Rural roads:** The project aims to upgrade rural roads and connect villages to the main road network, improving access to markets, healthcare, and education. **Hence statement 3 is not correct.**

  Benefits:

  - Improved connectivity and accessibility.
  - Enhanced economic growth and job creation.
  - Reduced travel time and transportation costs.
  - Boost to trade and commerce.
  - Strengthened national security and regional development.

- Thus, **Bharatmala is a transformative infrastructure initiative that aims to revolutionize India's road network, promote economic development, and enhance connectivity across the country.** Through strategic planning and implementation, it seeks to address the growing demand for efficient transportation and contribute to India's socio-economic progress. **Hence statement 4 is correct.**

Q 26. C

- **External Commercial Borrowings (ECB)** refers to the debt shouldered by an eligible entity in India for solely commercial purposes, that has been extended by external sources, i.e. from any recognized entity outside India. Its ambit include commercial loans that include **securitized instruments, bank loans,** suppliers' credit, buyers' credit, and bonds.

  Advantages of ECBs:

  - ECBs provide opportunity to borrow large volume of funds.
  - The funds are available for relatively long term.
  - Interest rate are also lower compared to domestic funds.
  - ECBs are in the form of foreign currencies. Hence, they enable the corporate to have foreign currency to meet the import of machineries etc.
  - However, there is a **limit** to the amount which can be withdrawn as an ECB. This amount, at present **is $40 billion.**

- Under Foreign Exchange Management (Borrowing & Lending) Regulations, 2018, a period of 3 years must be a minimum average maturity period for ECBs.
- **ECBs** can be raised in any convertible **foreign currency as well as in Indian rupee** (subject to RBI norms). Foreign Currency denominated ECBs have **forex hedging risk** due to foreign currency

difference. Indian Rupees denominated ECBs do not have hedging risk. **Hence statement 1 is correct and statement 3 is not correct.**

End uses of ECBs: RBI has placed certain restrictions to the use of ECBs. Hence money raised from ECBs **cannot be used** in

- **Real Estate Activities**
- Investment in Capital Markets
- Equity Investments
- On lending to entities except in case of NBFCs. **Hence statement 4 is correct.**

- **External Commercial borrowings (ECBs)** remained the **largest component** of external debt, with a share of 38.1 per cent, followed by non-resident deposits (23.9 per cent) and short-term trade credit (18.2 per cent). **Hence statement 2 is correct.**
- **Hence option (c) is the correct answer.**

Q 27. B

- **Recent Context:** A recent analysis by Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA) found that at least one-third of the Delhi's annual PM2.5 pollution can be attributed to Secondary pollutants, mostly Ammonium Sulphate.
- **Ammonium Sulphate:** Secondary pollutant (formed in the atmosphere from SO_2 oxidation and reaction with ammonia).
- **Ozone:** Secondary pollutant (formed via photochemical reactions involving NOx and VOCs in the presence of sunlight).
- **NOx:** Primary pollutant (directly emitted from combustion sources like vehicles and power plants).
- **Volatile Organic Compounds (VOCs):** Primary pollutants (emitted directly from fuels, solvents, industries, etc., though they act as precursors for secondary pollutants).
- **Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**

Q 28. B

- **India's steel industry is rapidly advancing toward the government's target of achieving 300 million tonnes per annum (MTPA) of crude steel capacity by FY2030-31, according to a private sector report released recently.**
- India has set the targets of achieving the total crude steel capacity of 300 MTPA and total crude steel demand/production of 255 MTPA by 2030-31 under the National Steel Policy 2017. By 2030-31, it is also envisaged to enhance the operational capacity of crude steel production of SAIL from existing 19.51 MTPA to around 35.65 MTPA tentatively.
- Government of India has notified National Steel Policy, 2017 which envisages development of a technologically advanced and globally competitive steel industry that provides environment for attaining self-sufficiency in steel production by providing policy support and guidance to steel producers. National Steel Policy covers all aspects of steel sector such as steel demand, steel capacity, raw material security, infrastructure and logistics, Research & Development (R&D) and energy efficiency.

Objectives of NSP:

- **To domestically meet entire demand of high-grade automotive steel, electrical steel, special steels and alloys for strategic applications by 2030- 31. Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- **Increase domestic availability of washed coking coal so as to reduce import dependence on coking coal from ~85% to ~65% by 2030-31. Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**

- Attain global standards in Industrial Safety and Health.
- To substantially reduce the carbon footprint of the steel industry.
- Research & Development in the sector through the establishment of Steel Research and Technology Mission of India (SRTMI).

Q 29. A
- **LIC of India was incorporated on 1st September, 1956** by amalgamating 243 Companies by the Act of Parliament called Insurance Act, 1956. LIC is governed by the Insurance Act 1938, LIC Act 1956, LIC Regulations 1959 and Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority Act 1999.
- **United India Insurance Company Limited was incorporated in 1938.** With the nationalization of General Insurance business in India, 12 Indian Insurance Companies, 4 Cooperative Insurance Societies and Indian operations of 5 Foreign Insurers, besides General Insurance operations of southern region of Life Insurance Corporation of India were merged with United India Insurance Company Limited.
- **The Oriental Insurance Company Ltd was incorporated in the year 1947.** In 2003 all shares of the company held by the General Insurance Corporation of India were transferred to the Government of India.
- **'Agriculture Insurance Company of India Limited' (AICIL)** was incorporated to exclusively cater to the insurance needs of the persons engaged in agriculture and allied activities in India under the Companies Act, 1956 on 20th **December 2002.** General Insurance Corporation of India (GIC), NABARD and four public sector general insurance companies have contributed towards the share capital of the Company.
- **Hence, option (a) is the correct answer.**

Q 30. A
- Shifting cultivation, also known as slash-and-burn or Jhum, is an ancient farming method where forest plots are cleared (cut and burned) to create fertile soil for temporary crops, then abandoned after a few years as nutrients deplete, allowing the land to regenerate naturally while farmers move to new plots, creating a cycle of cultivation and fallow periods. This subsistence practice relies on natural nutrient cycling, with ash enriching the soil, and is common in tropical regions, often seen as a sustainable system when land cycles are long enough, though it can cause deforestation and soil erosion if practiced too intensively.
- This type of farming is known by different names in different parts of the country such as "jhumming" in north-eastern states like Assam, Meghalaya, Mizoram, and Nagaland; "Pamlou" in Manipur, "Dipa" in Bastar district of Chhattisgarh, and "Bringa" or "Pama Dabi" or "Koman" in Odisha, "Kumari" in Western Ghats, "Valre" or "Waltre" in South-eastern Rajasthan, "Khil" in the Himalayan belt, and "Kuruwa" in Jharkhand.

  The ‘slash and burn’ agriculture is known as
  - ‘Milpa’ in Mexico and Central America, **Hence, Pair 1 is not correctly matched.**
  - ‘Conuco’ in Venezuela,
  - ‘Roca’ in Brazil, Hence, **Pair 2 is not correctly matched.**
  - Masole’ in Central Africa,
  - ‘Ladang’ in Indonesia**, Hence, Pair 3 is correctly matched.**
  - ‘Ray’ in Vietnam.

Q 31. B Context

- The e-Shram portal is a flagship initiative of the Ministry of Labour & Employment to build a National Database of Unorganised Workers (NDUW), seeded with Aadhaar.
- It is meant to strengthen delivery of social security and welfare schemes to workers who are outside the traditional EPFO/ESIC framework and largely employed in informal, scattered occupations.

Scope of the database: organised vs unorganised

- Official descriptions repeatedly define e-Shram as a database specifically for unorganised workers.
- The portal's objective is to create a centralised, Aadhaar-authenticated database of unorganised workers including construction workers, migrant workers, gig and platform workers, street vendors, domestic workers, and agriculture workers, among others.
- Workers already in the organised sector and covered under EPFO/ESIC are expected to receive social security through those systems, not via e-Shram.
- **Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**

Age-based eligibility for registration

- Any worker aged between 16 and 59 years, working in the unorganised sector, is eligible to register on the e-Shram portal, subject to not being covered by EPFO/ESIC.
- This age band reflects the productive working-age range targeted for social security mapping and future benefit delivery through schemes linked to the database.
- **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

Coverage of agriculture and allied sector workers

- Agriculture and allied activities employ a large share of India's informal workforce.
- The official eligibility lists for e-Shram explicitly include agriculture sector categories such as field-crop and vegetable growers, livestock and dairy workers, poultry workers, apiarists, silk growers, crop-farm workers, and mixed crop-and-livestock workers as unorganised workers eligible for registration.
- These workers, often seasonal and lacking formal contracts, are key beneficiaries of the portal's social security focus.
- **Hence, statement 3 is also correct.**

Q 32. A

- **Recent Context:** The pipeline provides early visibility of potential PPP projects to enable investors, developers, and other stakeholders to undertake more informed planning and investment decisions.
- The pipeline comprises 852 projects worth over ₹17 lakh crore to accelerate infrastructure development across sectors.

About the Public Private Partnership (PPP)

- PPP is a long-term contractual arrangement between a government or public authority and a private sector entity for the provision of public infrastructure or services.

Key PPP Models

- **In the EPC (Engineering, Procurement, and Construction) model,** the government provides 100% of the project finance. The private sector is simply hired as a contractor to design and build the project for a fixed price. Once the project is completed, the government takes over the operation and maintenance. **Hence, pair 1 is not correctly matched.**

- **Build Operate Transfer (BOT):** Private entity finances, designs, build, and operate a facility for a set period (earning via user fees) before transferring ownership to the public sector. **Hence, pair 2 is correctly matched.**
- **Hybrid Annuity Model (HAM)**: **A mix of EPC and BOT. The government pays 40% of the cost in milestone-linked installments; the developer raises the remaining 60% and recovers it through annuities. Hence, pair 3 is not correctly matched.**
- **Design Build Finance Operate (DBFO): Private party handles the entire lifecycle from design to operation.** The government retains ownership throughout, paying the private party via service fees or collected user tolls.

Q 33. A Why Four Labour Codes?

India earlier had 29 fragmented central labour laws, leading to:

- overlap,
- inconsistent definitions,
- multiple authorities,
- compliance complexity.

- To address this, Parliament consolidated them into four thematic Labour Codes, each based on a functional logic, not chronology.

Code on Wages, 2019

- Core Theme: “How wages are fixed and paid”
- This Code only deals with remuneration-related issues, cutting across sectors.

Subsumed Acts (4):

- Minimum Wages Act, 1948
- Payment of Wages Act, 1936
- Payment of Bonus Act, 1965
- Equal Remuneration Act, 1976

- Any Act dealing with standing orders, factories, PF, contract labour cannot fall under this Code. **Hence, pair 1 is not correctly matched.**

Industrial Relations Code, 2020

- Core Theme: “Relationship between employer, worker, and union”
- This Code governs collective employment relations.

Subsumed Acts (3):

- Trade Unions Act, 1926
- Industrial Employment (Standing Orders) Act, 1946
- Industrial Disputes Act, 1947

- Acts like Factories Act or EPF Act do not belong here. **Hence, pair 2 is not correctly matched.**

Code on Social Security, 2020

- Core Theme: “Income protection & welfare across life-cycle risks”
- This Code is about post-employment and contingency-based benefits.

Subsumed Acts (9):

- Employees' Provident Funds & MP Act, 1952
- Employees' State Insurance Act, 1948
- Payment of Gratuity Act, 1972
- Maternity Benefit Act, 1961
- Employees' Compensation Act, 1923
- Cine-Workers Welfare Act
- Building Workers Welfare Cess Act
- Unorganised Workers' Social Security Act
- Employment Exchanges Act

- Factories Act or Standing Orders Act cannot fall under this Code. **Hence, pair 3 is not correctly matched.**

Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions Code, 2020

- Core Theme: "Where and how work is performed"
- This Code consolidates all workplace condition laws.

Subsumed Acts (13):

- Factories Act, 1948
- Mines Act, 1952
- **Contract Labour (Regulation and Abolition) Act, 1970. Hence, pair 4 is correctly matched.**
- Inter-State Migrant Workmen Act, 1979
- Building and Other Construction Workers Act, 1996
- Dock Workers Act
- Plantation Labour Act
- Motor Transport Workers Act
- Beedi and Cigar Workers Act
- Sales Promotion Employees Act
- Working Journalists Act
- Cine-Workers Act
- Dangerous Machines Act

Q 34. C

- **Foreign Currency Convertible Bonds (FCCBs) mean a bond issued by an Indian company expressed in foreign currency, and the principal and interest in respect of which is payable in foreign currency**. Further, the bonds are required to be issued in accordance with the scheme viz., "Issue of Foreign Currency Convertible Bonds and Ordinary Shares (Through Depositary Receipt Mechanism) Scheme, 1993", and subscribed by a non-resident in foreign currency and convertible into ordinary shares of the issuing company in any manner, either in whole, or in part, on the basis of any equity related warrants attached to debt instruments.
- **Foreign Currency Exchangeable Bond (FCEB) means a bond expressed in foreign currency, the principal and interest in respect of which is payable in foreign currency, issued by an Issuing Company (often Indian) and subscribed to by a person who is a resident outside India,**

in foreign currency and exchangeable into equity share of another company, to be called the Offered Company, in any manner, either wholly, or partly or on the basis of any equity related warrants attached to debt instruments. The FCEB must comply with the "Issue of Foreign Currency Exchangeable Bonds (FCEB) Scheme, 2008", notified by the Government of India, Ministry of Finance, Department of Economic Affairs.

- **The Depository Receipts Scheme, 2014 was notified by the Government of India on 21st October, 2014 with a view to providing a comprehensive framework for the issue and listing of Depository Receipts (DRs) by Indian companies.** The Scheme enables Indian companies to raise capital from permissible jurisdictions abroad, against eligible securities, **through instruments such as American Depository Receipts (ADRs) and Global Depository Receipts (GDRs). Hence, option (c) is the correct answer.**

Q 35. A

- Fair Average Quality (FAQ) standards define the minimum acceptable quality for agricultural commodities, especially grains, for government procurement and trading, ensuring consistency by setting limits on moisture, impurities (like dust, stones, damaged grains, insect damage), and other specific parameters (like uric acid, aflatoxin) for different crops, acting as a benchmark for price support schemes.
- These norms, often set annually by central authorities, balance quality with practicality, allowing farmers to sell crops with minimal issues, while also providing objective criteria for traders and quality control agencies. **Hence option (a) is the correct answer.**

Q 36. D

- **Recent Context:** Union Environment Ministry panel has recommended environmental clearance for Kalai-II hydroelectric project on Lohit River in Arunachal Pradesh despite protest to conserve white-bellied heron bird.
- About White-bellied heron
- Other names: Imperial Heron, Great White-bellied Heron
- Features: Second-largest living heron species with distinct white belly,
- **Non-migratory but shows local/post-breeding dispersal. Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- Habitat: Undisturbed rivers and wetlands in the foothills of the Eastern Himalayas
- **Distribution: Indian subcontinent to Southeast Asia (India (Arunachal Pradesh, Assam), Bhutan, Bangladesh etc.). Hence, statement 3 is correct.**
- Conservation Status
- **IUCN Red List: Critically Endangered. Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- India: Placed in Schedule I under Wildlife Protection Act, 1972
- 

Q 37. C

- **Recent Context:** Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) highlighted that India must enhance silver processing and diversify imports to reduce reliance on finished silver.

  Silver

  - India imported about 21.4% of global silver trade in 2024, making it the world's largest consumer of finished silver.

  About Silver

  - It is a relatively soft, shiny metal.
  - Applications: Highest electrical and thermal conductivity makes it indispensable for electronics, circuit boards, connectors, batteries, and automotive systems.
  - Silver's antibacterial properties are used in wound dressings, medical-device coatings, catheters, surgical instruments, water purification systems, and pharmaceutical compounds.
  - **Natural Abundance: Silver occurs in ores such as argentite and chlorargyrite (horn silver). Hence, option (c) is the correct answer.**

Q 38. B

- **The second five year plan period was 1956–61. The strategy of growth laid emphasis on rapid industrialisation with a focus on heavy industries and capital goods.** The plan was developed by Professor Mahalanobis. Due to the assumption of a closed economy, shortages of food and capital were felt during this Plan. **Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**
- **The Ninth Plan (1997–2002) was launched when there was an all round 'slowdown' in the economy led by the South East Asian Financial Crisis (1996–97)**. Though the liberalisation process was still criticised, the economy was very much out of the fiscal imbroglio of the early 1990s. With a general nature of 'indicative planning', the Plan not only did target an ambitious high growth rate (7 per cent), but also tried to direct itself towards time-bound 'social' objectives. **It was first to explicitly adopt "Growth with Social Justice and Equality" as its central theme, focusing on poverty reduction, equitable development, and empowering marginalized communities alongside economic growth after the 1990s liberalization. Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

Q 39. C

- **Government approved the Export Promotion Mission (EPM) — a flagship initiative announced in the Union Budget 2025–26 to strengthen India's export competitiveness, particularly for MSMEs, first-time exporters, and labour-intensive sectors**. The Mission will provide a comprehensive, flexible, and digitally driven framework for export promotion, with a total outlay of Rs.25,060 crore for FY 2025–26 to FY 2030–31.

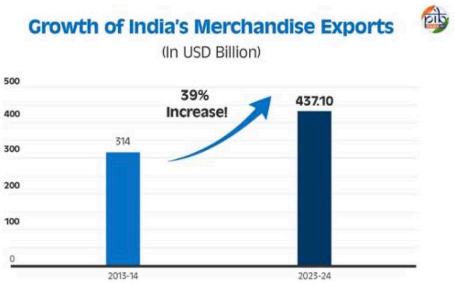
  The Mission will operate through two integrated sub-schemes:

  - **NIRYAT PROTSAHAN – focuses on improving access to affordable trade finance for MSMEs through a range of instruments** such as interest subvention, export factoring, **collateral guarantees**, credit cards for e-commerce exporters, and credit enhancement support for diversification into new markets. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
  - **NIRYAT DISHA – focuses on non-financial enablers that enhance market readiness and competitiveness,** including export quality and compliance support, assistance for international branding, packaging, and participation in trade fairs, export warehousing and logistics, inland transport reimbursements, and **trade intelligence and capacity-building initiatives. Hence, statement 1 is correct.**

  The Mission is expected to:

- facilitate access to affordable trade finance for MSMEs,
- enhance export readiness through compliance and certification support,
- improve market access and visibility for Indian products,
- boost exports from non-traditional districts and sectors, and
- generate employment across manufacturing, logistics, and allied service

Q 40. C

- According to World Bank Data, the world's export is growing at 2.5%, whereas India's export is growing at 7.1% (2024) outpacing global growth, and indicating the progress of the country on the international front. **The share of exports in Indian GDP has increased from 19.8% in 2015 to 21.2% in 2024,** which also indicates the growing relevance of exports in the Indian economy (World Bank). India's exports have seen a historic rise, reaching USD 778.21 billion in 2023-24. This marks a 67% increase from USD 466.22 billion in 2013-14. The growth reflects India's expanding role in global trade, driven by strong performances in both merchandise and services exports.
- **Merchandise exports have grown from USD 314 billion in 2013-14 to USD 437.10 billion in 2023-24, driven by a stronger manufacturing base and increased global demand. Hence, Statement-I is correct, but Statement-II is not correct.**
- 

- Service exports have expanded from USD 152 billion in 2013-14 to USD 341.11 billion in 2023-24, fueled by the rise of IT, financial, and business services.

Q 41. A **Ministry of Tourism** is the nodal agency to formulate national policies and programmes for the development and promotion of tourism. Augmenting tourism infrastructure, easing of visa regime, assurance of quality standards in services of tourism service providers, etc., are some of the responsibilities of the Ministry. The various initiatives of the Ministry are

- **Incredible India:** The Ministry, as part of its ongoing promotional activities, releases campaigns in the international and domestic markets under the Incredible India brandline, to promote various tourism destinations and products of India to increase foreign tourist arrivals and domestic visits within the country.
- **Swadesh Darshan Scheme:** Swadesh Darshan scheme is about developing theme based tourist circuits on the principles of high tourist value, competitiveness and sustainability in an integrated manner by synergizing efforts to focus on needs and concerns of all stakeholders.
- **PRASAD Scheme:** Under PRASAD scheme, 25 sites of religious significance have been identified for development. For example: Amaravati (Andhra Pradesh), Badrinath (Uttarakhand), Dwarka (Gujarat), Deoghar (Jharkhand), Belur (West Bengal), Gaya (Bihar) etc.

- **The National Mission on Monuments and Antiquities (NMMA)** is an Indian government agency responsible for maintaining cultural heritage database under the **Ministry of Culture** of the government of India. It was launched in 2007 aimed at studying, researching and preserving the cultural heritage of India.

- **Hence option (a) is the correct answer.**

Q 42. B **Land Ports Authority of India:** It is **a statutory body** established under the **Land Ports Authority of India Act, 2010**. It **functions under the Department of Border Management, Ministry of Home Affairs** with representation from the Ministry of External Affairs, the Ministry of Commerce and Industry, the Department of Revenue and other stakeholders. **Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**

- LPAI also associates with the concerned State Governments and Border Guarding Forces (BGFs) like BSF, SSB, ITBP, and Assam Rifles, deployed at the borders of India.
- LPAI **provides "single window" infrastructural facilities** such as warehouses; development of Integrated Check Posts (ICPs) examination sheds, parking bays, weighbridges, etc. for the cross border movement of passengers and goods at designated locations on the international land borders of India with Bangladesh, Myanmar, Nepal and Pakistan.

Functions:

- It plans, constructs, and maintains roads, terminals, and ancillary buildings other than national highways, State highways, and railways, at an **Integrated Check Posts (ICPs). Hence,statement 2 is correct.**
- It establishes and maintains warehouses, container depots, and cargo complexes for the storage or processing of goods with the establishment of hotels, restaurants, and restrooms at ICP.
- It plans, procure, install and maintain communication, security, goods handling and scanning equipment at an integrated check post.

Q 43. A

- **Foreign direct investment (FDI) refers to an ownership stake in a foreign company or project made by an investor, company, or government from another country. FDI is generally used to describe a business decision to acquire a substantial stake in a foreign business or to buy it outright to expand operations to a new region. It includes physical assets like factories, infrastructure, or specific companies.**
- **Whereas, Foreign Institutional Investment (FII) involves large organizations (banks, hedge funds, mutual funds) investing in a country's capital markets. It targets instruments such as shares, bonds, and government securities.**
- In India, the distinction between the two is officially based on ownership levels. If a foreign entity's stake is 10% or more, it is classified as FDI. If the stake is less than 10%, it is treated as FPI/FII.
- **Capital flight is the large-scale exodus of financial assets and capital from a country, typically triggered by political or economic instability, currency devaluation, or unfavorable policy changes**. Capital flight occurs when investors lose confidence in an economy for various reasons, and wish to protect the value of their investment. In a world of freely moving capital, the sudden exit of capital can act as a force of discipline on bad economic policies by starving the economy of precious investment capital. Capital flight can also be irrational, which provides opportunities for other investors to buy assets being sold rapidly at bargain prices.
- **Because of the specter of capital flight, most nations prefer foreign direct investment (FDI) rather than foreignInstitutional investment (FII).** After all, FDI involves long-term investments in factories and enterprises in a country, and it can be exceedingly difficult to liquidate at short

notice. On the other hand, portfolio investments can be liquidated and the proceeds repatriated in a matter of minutes, leading to this capital source often being regarded as “hot money.”

- **Thus, FII is more liquid investment than FDI which makes it proe to fly easily in case of capital flight. Hence, both the statements are correct and statement-II is the correct explanation of statement-I.**

Q 44. B

- **The Stand-by Arrangement (SBA) provides short-term financial assistance to countries facing balance of payments problems.** All member countries facing actual or potential external financing needs can use this instrument. **Most often used by advanced and emerging market countries, but low-income countries sometimes use the SBA together with the Standby Credit Facility (SCF)**. Historically, it has been the IMF lending instrument most used by advanced and emerging market countries. Through the years, the SBA has been upgraded to be more flexible and responsive to countries’ needs, and can also serve as a precautionary arrangement. **Hence, pair 1 is correctly matched.**
- **The Rapid Financing Instrument (RFI) provides prompt financial assistance to any IMF member country facing an urgent balance of payments need.** The RFI is one of the facilities under the General Resources Account (GRA) that provide financial support to countries, including in times of crisis. **Hence, pair 2 is not correctly matched.**
- **The Resilience and Sustainability Facility (RSF) provides affordable longer-term financing to support low-income and vulnerable middle-income countries** undertaking macro-critical reforms to reduce risks to prospective balance of payments (BoP) stability, including those related to climate change and pandemic preparedness. **Hence, pair 3 is correctly matched.**

Q 45. D

- **Today, India holds the 4th largest foreign exchange reserves in the world. As on November 28, 2025, India’s foreign exchange reserves stood at US$ 686.2 billion, providing a robust import cover of over 11 months.** Also reserves were sufficient to cover approximately 90 per cent of the country’s external debt of USD 711.8 billion as of September 2024, reflecting a strong buffer against external vulnerabilities. **Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**
- **Over the past decade, the share of gold in India’s foreign exchange reserves has nearly doubled, rising from below 7 per cent to almost 15 per cent.** Analysts note that this is the highest proportion of gold in the country’s total reserves since 1996-97, reflecting steady accumulation by the RBI and the surge in global bullion prices. **However, Foreign currency assets, which form the largest component of the reserves, constitute more than 90 per cent of India’s foreign exchange reserves.** Foreign exchange reservesare maintained as a multi-currency portfolio comprising major currencies, such as, US dollar, Euro, Pound sterling, Japanese yen, etc. **Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**

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- **In the year 2022-23, India's foreign exchange reserves slightly decreased in comparison to previous year. Hence, statement 3 is not correct.**

Q 46. A

- **National Highways & Infrastructure Development Corporation Ltd. (NHIDCL):** This was approved and a new corporate entity, the NHIDCL was set up, **under the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways to exclusively carry out the task of construction/ up-grading/widening of national highways in parts of the country which share international boundaries with neighboring countries** to promote regional connectivity on a sustainable basis.
- **The Commission of Railway Safety (CRS) is under the administrative control of the Ministry of Civil Aviation and is headed by the Chief Commissioner of Railway Safety,** with headquarters in Lucknow. CRS is responsible for matters relating to the safety of rail travel and train operation and discharges certain functions **as laid down in the Railways Act, 1989**which are of an inspectorial, investigatory, and advisory nature.
- **The Directorate General of Shipping, an attached office of the Ministry of Shipping, was established in 1949 to administer the Indian Merchant Shipping Act, 1958 on all matters relating to shipping policy and legislation; implementation of various international conventions relating to safety;** prevention of pollution and other mandatory regulations of the international maritime organizations; promotion of maritime education and training; examination and certification; supervision of other subordinate offices for their effective functioning, etc.
- **Airports Economic Regulatory Authority (AERA) is a statutory body constituted under the Airports Economic Regulatory Authority Act, 2008.** AERA is entrusted with the responsibility to regulate tariffs and other charges for the aeronautical services rendered at airports and to monitor the performance standards of airports. As an independent economic regulator, AERA aims to create a level playing field, foster healthy competition amongst all major airports, to encourage investment in airport facilities, and regulate tariffs for aeronautical services.
- **Hence option (a) is the correct answer.**

Q 47. B
- **Recent Context:** American biologist has been awarded the Tyler Prize for Environmental Achievement for her work on mycorrhizal networks.
- Tyler Prize is also called the "Nobel for the environment"

  About mycorrhizal networks
  - Definition: These are underground fungal networks in which mycorrhizal fungi connect the roots of multiple plants through hyphae(fungal threads).
  - Mycorrhizal fungi form a symbiotic association where plants provide carbohydrates to the fungi, and in return receive enhanced access to water and essential nutrients.
  - **The underground network of fungi in the forest ecosystem is known as the Wood Wide Web. Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**
  - Other Ecological Role: They are responsible for drawing down 13 billion tons of CO_2 into soil systems every year.

Q 48. C
- Recently, Australia Group celebrated its 40th anniversary.

  About Australia Group
  - Genesis: It was founded in 1985, in the wake of chemical weapons use in the Iran–Iraq war.
  - It is an informal arrangement with no legally binding obligations for participants.
  - It aims to allow exporters or transshipment countries to minimize the risk of further proliferation of chemical and biological weapons (CBW).
  - Participants: 43 participants (42 countries and the European Union).
  - **India became a member in 2018.**
- **India is a member of the Wassenaar Arrangement, Missile Technology Control Regime (MTCR), and the Australia Group. However, India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG), though it has received a waiver. Hence, India is part of three of the listed multilateral export control regimes.**
- **Hence, option (c) is the correct answer.**

Q 49. B
- **A significant inscription dating back to 1169 CE found in the Bhadrakali Temple (Prabhas Patan, Gujarat) has gained attention. It serves as a vital historical record detailing the evolution of the famous Somnath Temple and the patronage of the Solanki Dynasty.**

  About the Bhadrakali Inscription
  - **Location: Situated at Prabhas Patan, Gujarat, this 1169 CE inscription is embedded in the wall of the ancient Bhadrakali Temple. Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**
  - Context: It serves as a prashasti (eulogy) for Acharya Bhavabrihaspati, the spiritual preceptor of the Solanki (Chaulukya) King Kumarapala.
  - Chronology: The record provides a legendary history of the Somnath Temple across the four Yugas, mentioning its construction in gold, silver, wood, and finally stone by Bhimdev Solanki.
  - Patronage: It highlights the role of the Solanki dynasty in the temple’s revival, specifically Kumarapala’s efforts in the 12th century.

Q 50. A
- Recent Context: Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) launched ‘Param Shakti’ at Indian Institute of Technology Madras.

- The project has been funded under the National Supercomputing Mission (NSM).
- India’s Supercomputer
- PARAM 8000 is India’s first supercomputer. Param Pravega is the largest supercomputer. **Hence, pair 1 is not correctly matched.**
- PARAM Shivay was the first supercomputer assembled indigenously under the National Supercomputing Mission and installed at IIT (BHU) in 2019. India's first supercomputer overall was PARAM 8000. **Hence, pair 2 is not correctly matched.**
- AIRAWAT: **This is India's national AI supercomputing infrastructure** (AI Research Analytics and Knowledge Dissemination Platform). This pair is correctly matched. The AIRAWAT PoC (Proof of Concept) is funded by the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) and implemented by C-DAC, Pune. **Hence, pair 3 is correctly matched.**

Q 51. A

- **The 'Jalvahak' scheme was launched on 15th December 2024 to incentivize the movement of long-haul cargo via NW-1 (River Ganga), NW-2 (River Brahmaputra), and NW-16 (via IBP route, River Barak). Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- The ‘Jalvahak’ scheme encourages to reduce logistics costs, decongest road and railways, and adapting to a sustainable mode of transportation.
- The Scheme, valid for a period of three years, is expected to incentivize incremental modal shift of 6.51 Lakh tonnes of cargo to waterways in three years period.
- **The ‘Jalvahak’ scheme offers reimbursement upto 35% of total operating expenditure incurred while transporting cargo via waterways on NW 1 (Ganga river), NW 2 (Brahmaputra river) & NW 16 (Barak river) via Indo Bangladesh Protocol (IBP) route. Hence statement 2 is not correct.**
- To encourage the business proposition of vessel operators, the scheme encourages cargo owners to hire vessels owned or operated by organisations other than IWAI or ICSL. The incentive scheme is ideal for major shipping companies, freight forwarders, trade bodies and associations that handle bulk and containerised cargo.

Q 52. D

- The current account is in balance when receipts on the current account are equal to the payments on the current account. **A surplus current account means that the nation is a lender to other countries** and a deficit current account means that the nation is a borrower from other countries. **Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**

  Balance on Current Account has two components:

  - Balance of Trade or Trade Balance
  - Balance on Invisibles

  Balance of Trade (BOT) is the difference between the value of exports and the value of imports of goods of a country in a given period of time. Export of goods is entered as a credit item in BOT, whereas import of goods is entered as a debit item in BOT. It is also known as Trade Balance.

  - BOT is said to be in balance when exports of goods are equal to the imports of goods. Surplus BOT or Trade surplus will arise if the country exports more goods than what it imports. Whereas, Deficit BOT or Trade deficit will arise if a country imports more goods than what it exports.
- Net Invisibles is the difference between the value of exports and the value of imports of Invisibles of a country in a given period of time. Invisibles include services, transfers, and flows of income

that take place between different countries.

- A surplus in the current account of a country does not necessarily imply a surplus balance of trade. Even when there is a deficit in the balance of trade, the surplus in the balance of Invisibles can result in a current account surplus. **Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**

Q 53. B

Recent Context: Voyager 1 is expected to become the first human-made object to reach a distance of one light-day from Earth.

  - One light-day is the distance that light travels in 24 hours, which is about 16 billion miles away.

- **About Voyager 1**
- Launched in 1977 by NASA to fly by Jupiter and Saturn.
- Instruments: Imaging Science System (ISS), Ultraviolet Spectrometer (UVS), etc.

Key Achievements:

  - **First spacecraft to cross the heliosphere, the boundary where the influences from outside our solar system are stronger than those from our Sun.**
  - **First human-made object to venture into interstellar space. Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**

Q 54. C

- **Department of Economic Affairs (DEA) under the Ministry of Finance** grants infrastructure status to various sectors, including road, ports, shipping, railways, inland water transport, urban development, power, new and renewable energy, railways, and telecommunication.
- It maintains the Harmonized master list of infrastructure sub-sectors. This makes it easier for companies to raise long-term credit from banks and other financial institutions at lower rates for operating within these segments.

Recently the government (Department of Economic Affairs) has granted Infrastructure' status for exhibition and convention centers. This means it will be eligible for:

  - Access larger amounts of funds as External Commercial Borrowings (ECB)
  - Access longer-tenure funds from insurance companies and pension funds
  - Eligible to borrow from India Infrastructure Financing Company Limited (IIFCL)

- **Hence option (c) is the correct answer.**

Q 55. B

- India's power sector is among the most diversified in the world, with generation from conventional sources like coal, gas, hydro, and nuclear, as well as renewable sources such as solar, wind, biomass, and small hydro. With rising electricity demand, India continues to expand its energy capacity to support economic growth and sustainability goals.
- As of June 2025, **India's total installed power capacity has reached a significant milestone with 476 GW, led by 240 GW of thermal (approx 50%),** 110.9 GW of solar, and 51.3 GW of wind power, marking a strong shift towards renewable energy and energy security. **Hence, statement 3 is not correct.**

Global Leadership:

  - As per IRENA RE Statistics 2025, **India ranks 4th globally in Renewable Energy Installed Capacity,** 4th in Wind Power, and 3rd in Solar Power capacity. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**

- Expansion in Renewable Energy Capacity: Installed RE capacity has grown from 76.37 GW in March 2014 to 226.79 GW in June 2025, an increase of nearly 3 times.

Wind energy:

- Installed capacity increased from ~21 GW in 2014 to 51.3 GW by June 2025, more than doubling in a decade.
- 4.15 GW added in FY 2024–25 alone.
- **As per National Institute of Wind Energy, the estimated wind potential of the country is 1164 GW at 150 meters above ground level. Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

Q 56. C

- **India has achieved a significant milestone in the Global Innovation Index (GII) 2024, securing the 39th position among 133 global economies.** This leap in ranking reflects India's commitment to fostering a robust innovation ecosystem that is underpinned by strong policies, investment in research and development (R&D), and a collaborative environment for startups and industries. **In a span of nearly a decade, India has made tremendous strides in the GII rankings, rising from the 81st position in 2015 to 39th in 2024.**
- As per the latest available R&D statistics, the total R&D expenditure measured in terms of **Gross Expenditure on Research and Development (GERD) as a percentage of GDP (Government) is 0.66%, 0.66% and 0.64% during 2018-19, 2019-20 and 2020-21 respectively.**
- The Gross expenditure on R&D (GERD) in the country has been consistently increasing over the years and has more than doubled from Rs. 60,196.75 crore in 2010-11 to Rs. 127,380.96 crore in 2020-21, Therefore, India's GERD as a percentage of GDP remained between 0.6% to 0.7% which is below global average and lower than countries like China, South Korea and US. **Another factor contributing to this is the relatively low investment by India's private sector in GERD, accounting for only around 36%, whereas in the aforementioned countries, private sector contributions is more than 70%. Hence, Statement-I is correct, but Statement-II is not correct.**

Q 57. B

- **Recent Context:** Dhruv-NG (New Generation) recently completed its inaugural flight in Bengaluru.

About Dhruv-NG Helicopters

- **Platform: Hindustan Aeronautics Limited's ALH Dhruv is an indigenously developed, twin-engine multi-role helicopter. Hence, statement 1 is not correct, and statement 2 is correct.**
- **Variant:** Dhruv-NG is the **new-generation civilian version with modern avionics and systems.**
- **Roles:** Designed for transport, air ambulance, disaster relief, tourism, and utility missions.

Q 58. A

- The Agriculture Census in India is conducted at five yearly intervals to collect data on structural aspects of operational holdings in the country. The Agriculture Census programme is carried out in three phases at five yearly intervals with the cooperation of States/UTs. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- The Government of India provides financial and administrative support as well as all technical guidance to States/UTs required for Census operations. In each State/UT a nucleus staff of the State Government, designated as the State Agriculture Census Unit is responsible for coordinating the activities of the Agriculture Census Programme at the State/UT level.

- The Agriculture Census in the country is conducted with reference to the Agricultural year, which is from July to June. The first comprehensive Agriculture Census was conducted in the year 1970-71, and since then, nine more Agriculture Censuses have been conducted. **Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**

Q 59. D

- **Context:** Fixed-Term Employment (FTE) **was formally recognised under the Industrial Relations Code, 2020 as part of India's broader labour law reforms**. The reform seeks to address long-standing concerns in the Indian labour market—namely, excessive informality, lack of social security for temporary workers, and rigidity in hiring practices—while ensuring fairness and statutory protection for workers. **Hence statement 2 is not correct.**

  What Fixed-Term Employment Seeks to Achieve

  - **Fixed-Term Employment permits employers to hire workers for a clearly defined duration, as specified in the employment contract.** Unlike earlier contractual arrangements that often resulted in denial of benefits, the new framework integrates FTE workers within the formal labour law system. However, a clearly-stated definition does not mean guaranteed non-termination. **Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**
  - A key principle underlying this reform is "equal pay and equal benefits for equal work", irrespective of the tenure of employment.
  - Statutory Benefits and Parity with Permanent Workers

  Under the Industrial Relations Code:

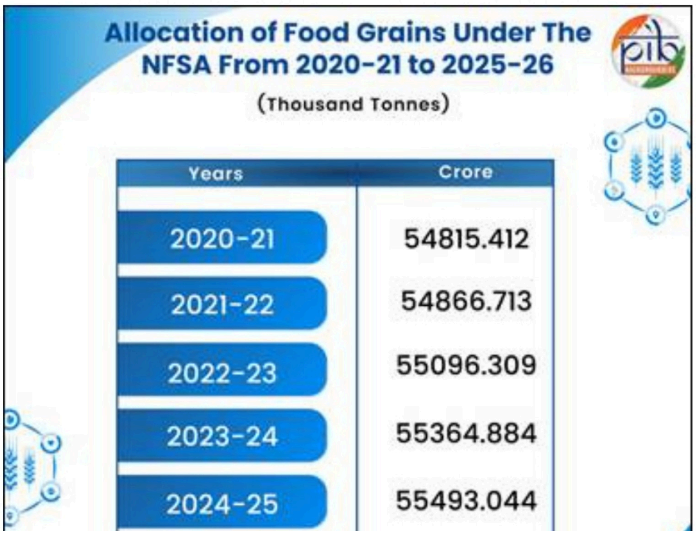
  - Fixed-term employees are entitled to wages, working hours, leave, social security benefits, and welfare provisions at par with permanent employees performing similar work.
  - The only distinction between permanent and fixed-term workers lies in the duration of employment, not in the conditions of service.
  - This provision ensures that flexibility for employers does not translate into vulnerability for workers.

  Gratuity Provision under Fixed-Term Employment

  - A significant reform relates to gratuity eligibility:
  - Fixed-term employees become eligible for gratuity after completing one year of continuous service, even if the contract ends at the completion of the term.
  - This is a deliberate deviation from the traditional five-year requirement applicable to permanent employees.
  - The change recognises the shorter tenure of FTE contracts and strengthens social security coverage for such workers.

Q 60. A

- The graph shows a steady rise in NFSA foodgrain allocation from 54.8 million tonnes (2020–21) to 55.49 million tonnes (2024–25), indicating a consistent increasing trend. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- While allocations increased every year, the largest absolute increase is observed between 2023–24 and 2024–25, not between 2022–23 and 2023–24. The allocation exceeds 55 million tonnes for the first time in 2022–23, not in 2024–25. **Hence statement 2 is not correct.**

- 

Allocation of Food Grains Under The NFSA From 2020-21 to 2025-26

(Thousand Tonnes)

Years	Crore
2020-21	54815.412
2021-22	54866.713
2022-23	55096.309
2023-24	55364.884
2024-25	55493.044

Q 61. B
- **The Indian manufacturing sector, with few mid-size firms, has the problem of the "missing middle." Few firms are to be found in the mid-size category of the firms in the Indian manufacturing sector. This missing middle is related to the wider problem of dualismsmall, unproductive firms co-exist with large, productive ones. The problem of dualism has negative implications for pro-poor growth, as most of the working poor in urban areas are employed in the smaller firms, which do not tend to grow over time. Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**
- Most firms operate with fewer than 10 workers, some between 10–50, and then there are large firms. But we lack medium-sized firms (200–500 workers). Small firms struggle with capital, skilled talent, technology, and supply chain linkages. Addressing this requires labour reforms, which fall under state governments.
- One of the issues is that India's labour laws often exempt smaller firms from compliance, promoting size-based incentives and inflexible regulations that encourage firms to remain small for benefits retention. E.g., Industrial Disputes Act (IDA), 1947, requires companies with over 100 employees to obtain government permission before retrenchment.

Q 62. B
- Recent Context: The discovery of stupas (man-made mounds) at Zehanpora underscores Kashmir's rich Gandhara Buddhist heritage and its historical role as a centre of Buddhist culture and learning.

  Zehanpora Site (Baramulla, North Kashmir)
  - Stupa structures belong to the Kushan period (1st–3rd century CE).
  - Located along the ancient Silk Route to Kandahar.
  - Other Findings: Evidence of wooden superstructures, an urban settlement complex (potentially chaityas and viharas), Kushan-era pottery, copper artefacts etc.
  - **Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**

Q 63. B
- Chitralekha is an open-source video transcreation platform (developed by AI4Bhārat) used for video translation and subtitling. The description provided in the question ("AI tool for engineering book translation") actually refers to Anuvadini, an AI tool developed by AICTE to translate technical and engineering textbooks into regional languages. **Hence, pair 1 is not correctly matched.**
- SUVAS (Supreme Court Vidhik Anuvaad Software) is an AI tool specifically designed to translate judicial documents and orders into regional languages to enhance access to justice. **Hence, pair 2 is**

correctly matched.

- MCA 3.0 is the revamped portal of the Ministry of Corporate Affairs. It utilizes AI and Machine Learning to simplify regulatory filings and improve compliance for companies. **Hence, pair 3 is correctly matched.**

Q 64. A

- The inward remittances are either part of the salary or come from the earnings that Indian migrant workers and the diaspora send to India — to their families and extended families.
- **During the calendar year 2024, India received $137.7 billion in inward remittances, according to the Reserve Bank of India. India continues to remain the largest recipient of inward remittances** — a trend maintained since 2008, according to the World Bank. In 2001, India's share in the world's total remittances was 11%. That increased to 14% in 2024. Also, India is the first country in the world to reach and cross the $100 billion mark in receiving remittances. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- According to the RBI Remittances Survey 2025, over half of India's remittances in FY24 came from advanced economies such as the United States, United Kingdom, Singapore, Canada, and Australia. **For that fiscal year, the United States emerged as the largest source (27.7% of total remittances in FY24), followed by the United Arab Emirates (19.2%). Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**

Q 65. D

- The Targeted Public Distribution System has undergone significant reforms to improve transparency, efficiency, and beneficiary convenience.
- Nearly all Fair Price Shops are equipped with **electronic Point of Sale (e-PoS) devices** enabling Aadhaar-based biometric authentication, which helps curb leakages and ensure rightful delivery.
- The One Nation One Ration Card (ONORC) initiative **allows beneficiaries to access their entitlements from any Fair Price Shop** across the country, enhancing portability, especially for migrant workers.
- Additionally, in select Union Territories such as Chandigarh and Puducherry, the **food subsidy is transferred directly into beneficiaries' bank accounts under a Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) system.** Hence, all the listed features form part of TPDS reforms
- **Hence option (d) is the correct answer.**

Q 66. D

- APMCs are constituted under respective state government APMC Acts, as agriculture is a state subject in the Indian Constitution. The APMCs acts were adopted by various states at different times (e.g., the first APMC Act was enacted in Punjab in 1961, Maharashtra in 1963). Agricultural Produce Committees have been established under the Maharashtra Agricultural Produce Marketing (Development and Regulation) Act, 1963 and Rules, 1967. **Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**
- As per the act, the State is divided into several market areas, each of which is administered by a separate Agricultural Produce Market Committee (APMC) which imposes its own marketing regulation (including fees).
- Apart from that, legal persons, growers, and local authorities are permitted to apply for the establishment of new markets for agricultural produce in any area. There will be no compulsion on the growers to sell their produce through existing markets administered by the Agricultural Produce Market Committee (APMC). **Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**

- Separate provision is made for notification of 'Special Markets' in any market area for specified agricultural commodities. Provision for Contract Farming, allowing direct sale of farm produce to contract farming sponsors from farmer's field. **Hence, statement 3 is not correct.**
- Since APMC Acts are state-level legislations, their implementation, rules, and market fees vary from state to state, leading to fragmented and non-uniform agricultural market regulations across India. The lack of uniformity is a major reason for the call for a national common market (e.g., e-NAM).

Q 67. A

- **The first important reform in the external sector was made in the foreign exchange market. In 1991, as an immediate measure to resolve the balance of payments crisis (by making imports costlier and exports cheaper), the rupee was devalued against foreign currencies. This led to an increase in the inflow of foreign exchange. It also set the tone to free the determination of the rupee value in the foreign exchange market from government control. Now, more often than not, markets determine exchange rates based on the demand and supply of foreign exchange. Hence, option (a) is the correct answer.**
- The fiscal deficit was a major cause of the overall economic crisis, but currency devaluation is an exchange rate policy, not a direct fiscal measure to reduce government spending or increase tax revenue.
- Devaluation makes imports costlier, which tends to increase domestic prices (inflation) and thus decreases the general purchasing power of citizens for imported goods.
- Devaluation was part of a broader package of reforms (Liberalization, Privatization, Globalization) aimed at attracting foreign investment by making Indian assets and investments cheaper for foreign entities, not discouraging them.

Q 68. C

- **Recent Context:** Traditional harvest festivals are being celebrated in different parts of India.
- These festivals, celebrated under different names and customs across the country, mark the change of seasons, the Sun's northward journey (Uttarayana), and the harvest of crops.

  Traditional Harvest Festivals

  - **Makar Sankranti (Maharashtra): It marks the Sun's transition into Capricorn. Hence, pair 1 is correctly matched.**
  - Uttarayana (Gujarat and Rajasthan): It is known for kite flying, which commemorates the Sun's rise and is a day of joy and celebration.
  - **Pongal (Tamil Nadu): It marks four-day harvest festival that includes Thai Pongal, Mattu Pongal, Kaanum Pongal, and Bhogi, people make the rice and lentil dish Pongal. Hence, pair 2 is correctly matched.**
  - Lohri (Punjab): Celebrated a day before Makar Sankranti, it marks the harvest of Rabi crops and is celebrated around bonfires with folk songs, Bhangra and Gidda. **Gujarat is associated with Uttarayana (kite festival) during the same period. Hence, pair 4 is not correctly matched.**
  - **Magh Bihu (Assam): It celebrates the end of the harvest season with community feasts, traditional games and bonfires known as Meji. Hence, pair 3 is correctly matched.**
  - Kanuma (Telangana): It is a festival to express thankfulness and admiration towards the agriculture sector.

Q 69. D Context: When does CSR apply?

Section 135(1) of the Companies Act, 2013 lays down that CSR applies to every company that, during the immediately preceding financial year, satisfies any one of the following:

- Net worth of ₹500 crore or more, or
- Turnover of ₹1,000 crore or more, or
- Net profit of ₹5 crore or more.

- The wording "every company" covers public, private, listed, unlisted, holding, subsidiary and even foreign companies with a branch or project office in India, provided they meet one of these criteria.

Applicability across company types:

Given this threshold-based approach:

- An unlisted public company is covered if it crosses any threshold. **Hence, option 1 is correct.**
- A listed public company is covered if it crosses any threshold (many will, but listing itself is not the test). **Hence, option 2 is correct.**
- An unlisted private company is equally covered if it meets the net worth, turnover or profit thresholds. **Hence, option 3 is correct.**
- A listed private company (rare but possible) is also covered on the same basis. **Hence, option 4 is also correct.**

- No category in the list enjoys a blanket exemption from CSR solely because it is private, unlisted, or listed; what matters is the financial threshold, not the label public/private or listed/unlisted.

Q 70. C

- A '**Swiss Challenge**' is a way to award a project to a private player on an unsolicited proposal. The government called for bids and it may enter into direct negotiations with a private player who show interest and submits a proposal for such project.
- These projects are considered to fill the gaps in infrastructure and the innovation that private players bring. Various states have used the Swiss Challenge to award projects in sectors including IT, ports, power, and health.
- Recently Government has proposed to redevelop about 400 railway stations through 'open invitation' from interested parties.
- There are various concerns raised w.r.t Swiss challenge such as the lack of transparency and competition while dealing with unsolicited proposals, crony capitalism, and allow companies space to employ dubious means to bag projects.
- A strong legal and regulatory framework is required to award projects under the Swiss Challenge method. **Hence option (c) is the correct answer.**

Q 71. B

- **Recent Context:** India added 387 MW in data centre capacity in 2025, compared to 191 MW in 2024, reflecting a year-on-year growth of 103 per cent, according to a report.
- Initiatives to promote Data Centre Ecosystem in India
- Draft Data Centre Policy (2020): Seeks to promote domestic manufacturing of data centre-related products.
- Infrastructure Status to data centres with more than 5 MW capacity of IT load.

- **India’s first hyperscale data centre ‘Yotta D1’ has been set up in Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh. Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**
- Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI): Recommended Data Centre Incentivization Scheme (DCIS), Data Centre Economic Zones (DCEZs) etc.

Q 72. B

- **Recent Context:** Analysis of samples returned by NASA’s OSIRIS-REx mission from asteroid Bennu shows the presence of Sugars, Amino acids, all five nucleobases of DNA & RNA, etc., signalling complete molecular inventory needed for life.

  About OSIRIS-REx (Origins, Spectral Interpretation, Resource Identification and Security-Regolith Explorer)

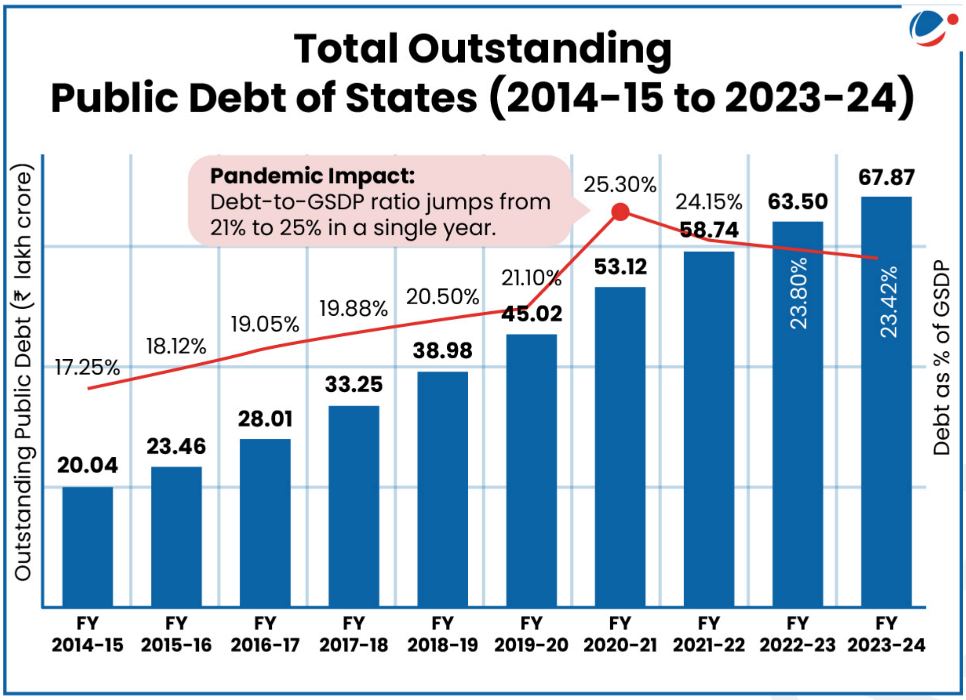
  - **It is the first US mission to collect a sample from an asteroid. Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**
  - Returned: Sep 24, 2023, to drop off a capsule with material from asteroid Bennu.
  - New Mission: Spacecraft was renamed OSIRIS-APEX and sent to explore asteroid Apophis in 2029.

  About Asteroid Bennu

  - Origin: The rocks composing Bennu formed ~4.6 billion years ago, during the early formation of the Solar System; part of a primeval parent body that was later destroyed by a massive collision.
  - Formation zone: Likely formed in the main asteroid belt between Mars and Jupiter and later drifted towards earth.
  - Orbital proximity: Bennu makes its closest approach to Earth every 6 years.

Q 73. A

- **Recent Context:** CAG releases ‘State Finances 2023-24’ Report.
- It is the 2nd edition which presents an overview of the finances of all 28 States in FY 2023-24.
- Since the COVID-19 pandemic in FY 2021, the absolute value (outstanding amount) of public debt for Indian states has shown a steady year-on-year increase. As of March 31, 2024, the total debt reached approximately ₹67.87 lakh crore. This increase is driven by persistent fiscal deficits and the need to fund both capital projects and high "committed expenditures" (salaries, pensions, and interest). **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- While the debt in absolute terms has risen, the Debt-to-GSDP ratio (debt as a percentage of the economy) has fluctuated and has not "consistently exceeded 25 per cent." A**fter a spike during the pandemic (where it did cross 25-30% for many states due to contracting GSDP), the aggregate ratio for all states combined stabilized as the economy recovered. Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**

- 

Q 74. B

- Tourism sector is one of the fastest growing economic sectors with a significant impact on employment and accelerates regional development with a multiplying effect on the activity of related sectors. **The tourism sector contributes 5% to India's GDP, further highlighting its crucial role in the country's economic growth. Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**
- Facilitative visa regime is a pre requisite for increasing inbound tourism. As on December, 2024, **e-visa facility has been extended to the nationals of 167 Countries** under 9 sub-categories such as 'e-Tourist Visa', 'e-Business Visa' etc. The e-Visa is valid for entry through 31 designated Airports and 6 designated seaports. **Hence statement 2 is correct.**
- **The Ministry of Tourism has set up National Integrated Database of Hospitality Industry, (or NIDHI),** a technology driven system, aligned with our Hon'ble Prime Minister's vision of an "Atmanirbhar Bharat", which is to **facilitate digitalization and promote ease of doing business for hospitality & tourism sector.** This initiative has been upgraded as **NIDHI+ to have more inclusivity**, that is, of not only classification/approval of Accommodation Units, but also approval/ classification/registration of Travel agents, Tour Operator etc. **Hence, statement 3 is correct.**

Q 75. B

- **The Model Concession Agreement (MCA) serves as a standard framework for Public-Private Partnership (PPP) projects in India.** It lays down the terms and conditions for the implementation of infrastructure projects, ensuring uniformity and clarity in contractual obligations between public authorities and private players. MCAs have been widely used in sectors like highways, ports, and airports.

  Key features of the MCA include:

  - **Risk-sharing mechanism:** Defines how risks are allocated between public and private sectors.
  - **Revenue model:** Details how the private player will earn revenue, such as user charges or annuity payments.
  - **Concession period:** Specifies the duration for which the private sector will operate the project before transferring it back to the government (as in BOT or BOOT models).
  - **Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**

Q 76. B

- As per the Swiss Re Report, **India remained the 10th largest insurance market in the world by nominal premium volumes** in 2024, with a global market share of 1.8 per cent. **Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**
- **Insurance penetration and density** are two metrics often used to assess the level of development of the insurance sector in a country. While insurance penetration is measured as the percentage of insurance premiums to GDP, insurance density is calculated as the ratio of premium to population (per capita premium).
- In 2024-25, **India's insurance penetration remained at 3.7 per cent as in 2023-24.** The insurance penetration for Life Insurance industry declined from 2.8 per cent in the previous year to 2.7 per cent during 2024-25. The penetration with respect to Non-Life Insurance Industry remained same at 1 per cent during 2024-25 as in 2023-24.
- In 2024-25, **the insurance density** in India showed a modest rise, increasing from USD 95 in 2023-24 to **USD 97 in 2024-25.** Whereas **World's insurance density is USD 943 in 2024-25. Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

Q 77. C

- India, endowed with diverse agro-climatic zones, cultivates an extensive range of tropical, sub-tropical, and temperate fruits and vegetables. It stands as the world's largest producer of several agricultural and horticultural crops, including lime, lemon, ginger, and okra. Additionally, India ranks as the second-largest producer of staple vegetables such as potatoes, onions, cauliflowers, brinjal, and cabbages, and is at the forefront in fruit production, particularly bananas, papayas, and mangoes. As per the final estimates of production of horticultural crops for 2023–24, India's total horticulture production is estimated at 354.74 million tonnes, a slight decrease of 0.65% compared to the previous year.
- India is the largest producer of onions, ginger and okra among vegetables and ranks second in the production of potato, cauliflower, brinjal, cabbage etc. Amongst fruits, the country ranks first in the production of bananas (25.56%), mangoes (including mangosteens and guavas) (44.46%) and papayas (38.64%). **Hence, points 1 and 5 are correct.**
- India ranks as the world's largest producer of pulses, contributing around 25-28% of global output, while also being the largest consumer and importer due to high domestic demand, with major production from states like Madhya Pradesh. **Hence, point 2 is correct.**
- India ranks as the second-largest wheat producer globally, after China, and its top wheat-producing states are consistently Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, and Punjab, followed by Haryana and Rajasthan, crucial for national food security. **Hence, point 3 is not correct.**
- India ranks second globally in sugarcane production after Brazil, with Uttar Pradesh leading as India's top producing state, followed by Maharashtra and Karnataka, forming the backbone of the nation's sugar industry and supporting millions of farmers. **Hence, point 4 is not correct.**

Q 78. A

- **Recent Context:** China's Experimental Advanced Superconducting Tokamak (EAST) or Artificial Sun, kept plasma stable at extreme densities, previously seen as a major obstacle in nuclear fusion.
- The **Greenwald limit is an empirical limit in nuclear fusion research that sets the theoretical maximum density for a stable plasma in a tokamak** (a type of fusion reactor). Exceeding this limit typically causes the plasma to become unstable and collapse, an event known as a disruption. Achieving high plasma density is crucial for fusion power production, so scientists are actively

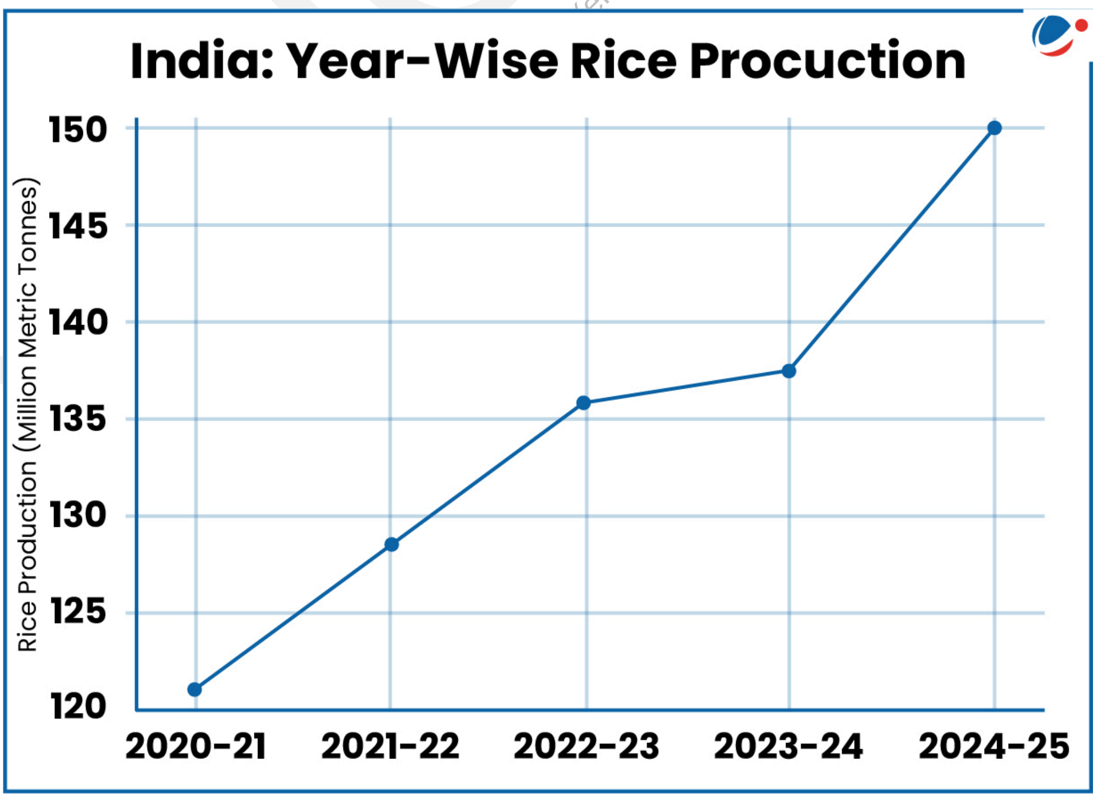
researching ways to operate reactors at or beyond this limit. **Hence option (a) is the correct answer.**

- **Option (b):** the maximum achievable efficiency of solar photovoltaic cells. This is related to the Shockley-Queisser limit, which deals with solar cell efficiency, not plasma density.
- **Option (c):** the critical population density affecting species survival in conservation biology. This is a concept related to biology and ecology (e.g., Allee effect), and has no relation to plasma physics.
- **Option (d):** the orbital decay limit of artificial satellites around Earth. This involves atmospheric drag and orbital mechanics, which are unrelated to fusion energy research.

Q 79. B

- **Recent Context:** India becomes world's largest rice producer, surpasses China: Agriculture Minister. Union Agriculture Minister also released 184 new high-yielding seed varieties for 25 crops.
- About Rice Crop
- Type: Major food crop of the world and staple diet of the tropical and sub-tropical regions.

  Growth Conditions:
  - Rice is grown under varying conditions in India from 8°N to 30°N latitude and from sea level to about 2,500 metre altitude.
  - Grown in variety of soils including silts, loams and gravels and can tolerate acidic as well as alkaline soils.

    Abundant rainfall (100-150cm), high humidity and high temperature (30°C during day and 20°C at night).
    - Paddy is a semi-aquatic plant that requires standing water (averaging 10–15 cm) for three-quarters of its growing season.
    - It grows best in impermeable subsoil with a pH between 5.5 and 6.5.
  - 

  Cropping Seasons in India: Rice is grown in three distinct seasons based on the region:
  - **Aman (Winter rice): Sown in June–July and harvested in November–December.**

- **Aus (Autumn rice): Sown in May–June and harvested in September–October.**
- **Boro (Summer rice): Cultivated between November and May, often in areas that remain moist during winter. Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**

Q 80. C **Legal Framework for setting up of Airport**

- The Constitution of India includes **aerodromes in Item 29 of the Union List**, which implies that the Central Government alone has legislative and executive powers relating to airports.
- The primary responsibility for the development of airports rests with the Central Government. The Union of India alone has the competence to legislate in respect of: "Airways, aircraft, and air navigation; provision of aerodromes; regulation and organization of air traffic and aerodromes; provision for aeronautical education and training and regulation of such education and training provided by states and other agencies."
- The **Aircraft Act, 1934** (the "Aircraft Act") and the Rules made thereunder by the Central Government govern the development, maintenance, and operation of all airports, including greenfield airports. Under the Act, the **Central Government has the sole right to grant a license for setting up an airport, and the operations of the airport** would be subject to its licensing conditions. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- The **Airports Authority Act** (the "AAI Act") was enacted by the Central Government in 1994, which stated that all Government airports are to be developed, financed, operated, and maintained by the Airport Authority of India ("AAI"). However, the AAI Act enables AAI to grant a concession to a private entity, which has entrusted the tasks of financing, development, operation, and maintenance of an airport by AAI. As such, greenfield airports to be developed by the Central Government could adopt the concession route if private participation were envisaged.
- The **Airports Authority of India or AAI is a statutory body, under the jurisdiction of the Directorate General of Civil Aviation, Ministry of Civil Aviation. Hence, statement 1 is correct.**

Q 81. B **Most-favoured-nation (MFN): Under the WTO agreements, countries cannot normally discriminate between their trading partners. Grant someone a special favour (such as a lower customs duty rate for one of their products) and you have to do the same for all other WTO members.**

- This principle is known as most-favoured-nation (MFN) treatment.It is so important that it is the first article of the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT), which governs trade in goods. MFN is also a priority in the General Agreement on Trade in Services (GATS) (Article 2) and the Agreement on Trade-Related Aspects of Intellectual Property Rights (TRIPS) (Article 4), although in each agreement the principle is handled slightly differently
- **The Most Favoured Nation principle was designed to prevent countries from giving different treatment to one partner over the other.**

National treatment: Treating foreigners and locals equally Imported and locally-produced goods should be treated equally — at least after the foreign goods have entered the market. The same should apply to foreign and domestic services, and to foreign and local trademarks, copyrights and patents.

- **This principle of "national treatment" (giving others the same treatment as one's own nationals) is also found in all the three main WTO agreements** (Article 3 of GATT, Article 17 of GATS and Article 3 of TRIPS), although once again the principle is handled slightly differently in each of these. National treatment only applies once a product, service or item of intellectual property has entered the market.

- **There are no WTO definitions of "developed" and "developing" countries. Members announce for themselves whether they are "developed" or "developing" countries.** However, other members can challenge the decision of a member to make use of provisions available to developing countries. **Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**

Q 82. B What is the Ybrant Programme?

- Launched by: Indian Institute of Corporate Affairs (IICA) in collaboration with WNS Global Services
- Nature: A six-month blended learning programme

Focus areas:

- The programme aims to bring CSR, ESG and sustainability into mainstream management education, so that future managers and CEOs align business performance with positive social and environmental impact rather than focusing only on profit metrics. **Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**
- Its 15-module curriculum covers: basics of CSR/sustainability, global CSR trends, Indian CSR laws, ESG reporting and impact assessment, corporate governance and responsible leadership—confirming that the focus is on integrating business decisions with ESG and social impact considerations,

Broader objective:

- To nurture a new cadre of professionals who can align business performance with social and environmental responsibility.
- The programme responds to the rapid expansion of India's CSR ecosystem and the growing importance of ESG-driven business decisions.

Q 83. B **Government policy on disinvestment consists of**:

- Strategic Disinvestment/Privatization and
- Minority Stake Sale in CPSEs

- **Strategic Disinvestment implies the entire or substantial sale (more than 50%) of the Government shareholding of a CPSE along with transfer of management control. In case of Privatization, which is a subset of strategic disinvestment, the Government equity in CPSE and its management control is transferred to a private strategic buyer(s) and in other cases of strategic disinvestment, the Government equity is transferred to another CPSE along with control. Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**

Minority Stake Sale in certain CPSEs are carried out without transfer of management control through various SEBI-approved methods like Initial Public Offer (IPO), Offer for Sale (OFS), Buyback of shares, etc. These methods play an important role in strengthening the capital market through:

- Increasing the float of well performing CPSE's
- Providing an opportunity to retail investors to participate in an extended range of stocks and
- Increasing liquidity and depth of the capital market

Q 84. D

- **4th edition of Export Preparedness Index (EPI) released by the NITI Aayog. Hence, option (d) is the correct answer.**

  About EPI

  - EPI is a comprehensive assessment of export readiness across India's States and Union Territories (UTs).
  - It is aligned with India's USD 1 trillion merchandise export target by 2030.

    Key Pillars & Indicators: Structured around four pillars, further disaggregated into 13 sub-pillars and 70 indicators.

    - **Pillars and Weightage:** Export Infrastructure (20%), Business Ecosystem (40%), Policy & Governance (20%) and Export Performance (20%)
    - **Sub-indicators:** Trade & Logistics Infrastructure, Human Capital, etc.

Q 85. C

- The fifth five-year plan was launched in the year 1974. It proposed to achieve two main objectives: 'removal of poverty' (Garibi Hatao) and 'attainment of self-reliance. **Hence option (c) is the correct answer.** 'Promotion of high rate of growth, better distribution of income and significant growth in the domestic rate of savings were seen as key instruments.
- Due to high inflation, cost calculations for the Plan proved to be completely wrong and the original public sector outlay had to be revised upwards. After promulgation of emergency in 1975, the emphasis shifted to the implementation of Prime Ministers 20 Point Programme. FYP was relegated to the background and when Janta Party came to power in 1978, the Plan was terminated.

Q 86. D

- The balance of payments (BOP), also known as the balance of international payments, is a statement of all transactions made between entities in one country and the rest of the world over a defined period, such as a quarter or a year. It summarizes all transactions that a country's individuals, companies, and government bodies complete with individuals, companies, and government bodies outside the country.

  Transfers payments (official, private) represent receipts and payments without a quid pro quo. Transfer payments are the receipts that the citizens of a nation get for free', without having to provide any commodities or services in return. Transfers are further classified into Official transfers and private transfers.

  - Official transfer receipts represent Contra entries for cash receipts and value of **aid received in kind from foreign Governments and institutions and debits cover contributions to international organisations and official grants in cash or kind extended to foreign Government.**
  - Private transfer receipts include repatriation of savings, **remittances for family maintenance, contributions and donations to religious and charitable institutions and the like.**
- **Non-resident deposits is an important component of capital account in the Balance of Payments. These are the deposits made by non-resident Indians (NRI) who keep their surplus funds with Indian Banks.**
- **Hence option (d) is the correct answer.**

Q 87. B

- Cattle Breeds- Karan Fries and Vrindavani

- The government has registered two high-yielding synthetic cattle breeds, Karan Fries and Vrindavani.
- **Also, new indigenous breeds of cattle and buffalo have been recognised, such as Medini (Jharkhand), Rohikhandi (Uttar Pradesh), and Melghati (Maharashtra). Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**
- Significance of synthetic cattle breeds: Enhanced milk productivity without compromising climate adaptability and disease resistance.

Q 88. B

- Government fixes Minimum Support Prices (MSPs) for 22 mandated agricultural crops based on the recommendations of the Commission for Agricultural Costs & Prices (CACP), after considering the views of State Governments and Central Ministries/Departments concerned and other relevant factors.
- While recommending MSP, CACP considers various factors viz. cost of production, overall demand-supply situations of various crops in domestic and world markets, domestic and international prices, inter-crop price parity, terms of trade between agriculture and non-agriculture sector, likely effect of price policy on rest of economy and a minimum of 50 per cent as the margin over the cost of production.
- The production cost computed by CACP includes all paid out costs such as those incurred on a**ccount of hired human labour, bullock labour/machine labour, rent paid for leased land, expenses incurred on use of material inputs like seeds, f**ertilizers, manures, irrigation charges, depreciation on implements and farm buildings, **interest on working capital,** diesel/electricity for operation of pump sets etc, miscellaneous expenses and i**mputed value of family labour. Hence, points 1, 2 and 3 are correct.**
- Aligned with the commitment outlined in the Union Budget 2018-19, the Government has consistently raised MSPs to ensure they are set at least 50 per cent above the All India weighted average Cost of Production. Notably, this calculation includes considerations such as family labour, acknowledging the collective efforts of entire farming households rather than solely focusing on individual farmers.
- **Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**

Q 89. D

- Recent Context: Government accelerated Sawalkot hydropower project along with Ratle and Dulahasti amid tensions over the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT).

  Sawalkot Hydropower Dam.
  - About Sawalkot Hydropower Project
  - Location: Chenab River, Jammu and Kashmir.
  - Type: 1,856-MW project run-of-the-river project.
  - **Other Projects on Chenab River: Dulhasti-I, Baglihar and Salal. Hence, option (d) is the correct answer.**
  - Under construction: Ratle, Dulhasti II, Kiru, and Kwar projects.

Q 90. C

- To promote FDI, the Government has put in place an investor-friendly policy, wherein most sectors, except certain strategically important sectors, are open for 100% FDI under the automatic route. **More than 90% of the FDI inflow is received under the automatic route. "Automatic route"**

means the entry route through which investment by a person resident outside India does not require the prior approval of the Reserve Bank of India or the Central Government.

- ◦ **"Government Route" means** the entry route through which investment by a person resident outside India requires prior Government approval and foreign investment received under this route shall be in accordance with the conditions stipulated by the Government in its approval.

- **As a result, FDI inflows have seen a steady rise—from USD 36.05 billion in FY 2013–14 to USD 81.04 billion (provisional) in FY 2024–25, marking a 14% increase from USD 71.28 billion in FY 2023–24. Hence,Statement-I is correct, but Statement-II is not correct.**
- In the recent past, reforms in the FDI Policy have been undertaken in sectors such as Defence, Insurance, Petroleum & Natural Gas, Telecom and Space. FDI in the Defence sector is allowed up to 74% through Automatic Route (from earlier 49%) for companies seeking new industrial licenses. Further, 100% FDI in the Telecom Sector is allowed under the Automatic Route. FDI sectoral cap in the insurance sector has been revised from 49% to 74% under the automatic route. The Union Budget 2025 also announced the further increase of FDI sectoral cap for the insurance sector from 74% to 100%. This enhanced limit will be available for those companies, which invest the entire premium in India.

Q 91. D

- Auditing in private companies in India is primarily governed by the Companies Act, 2013. This Act and the related rules, specifically the Companies (Audit and Auditors) Rules, 2014 and the Companies (Accounts) Rules, 2014, outline the detailed requirements and procedures. **Hence option (d) is the correct answer.**
- One of the core objectives of the Companies Act, 2013 is to strengthen corporate governance by ensuring that statutory auditors remain independent, objective, and free from conflicts of interest. This objective gained prominence after corporate failures revealed how long-standing auditor–management relationships could compromise audit quality.

Q 92. C

- Recent Context: The Ministry of Women and Child Development launched PANKHUDI Portal.

  About PANKHUDI Portal

  - ◦ **It is an integrated Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and partnership facilitation single-window digital platform. Hence, option (c) is the correct answer.**
  - ◦ It brings together individuals, Non-Resident Indians (NRIs), Non-Governmental Organisations (NGOs), corporate entities, and government agencies.
  - ◦ The portal streamlines and unifies voluntary and institutional contributions across key thematic areas including nutrition, health, Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE), child welfare, etc.
  - ◦ Aim: Strengthening coordination, transparency, and structured stakeholder participation in initiatives for women and child development.

Q 93. C

- **Foreign Direct Investment means investment through equity instruments by a person resident outside India in an unlisted Indian company; or in 10% or more of the post issue paid-up equity capital on a fully diluted basis of a listed Indian company.**

  FDI is prohibited in:

  - ◦ Lottery Business including Government/private lottery, **online lotteries,** etc.

- Gambling and Betting including casinos etc.
- Chit funds
- **Nidhi company**
- Trading in Transferable Development Rights (TDRs)

  Real Estate Business or Construction of Farm Houses
  - **'Real estate business' shall not include development of townships, construction of residential /commercial premises, roads or bridges and Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) registered and regulated under the SEBI (REITs) Regulations 2014.**
- Manufacturing of cigars, cheroots, cigarillos and cigarettes, of tobacco or of tobacco substitutes

  Activities/sectors not open to private sector investment e.g. (I) **Atomic Energy** and (II) Railway operations (other than permitted activities mentioned in permitted sectors). **Hence, option (c) is the correct answer.**
  - Foreign technology collaboration in any form including licensing for franchise, trademark, brand name, management contract is also prohibited for Lottery Business, Gambling and Betting activities.

- FDI Policy provides that FDI is a capital account transaction and thus any violation of FDI regulations are covered by the penal provisions of the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA). Reserve Bank of India administers the FEMA and Directorate of Enforcement under the Ministry of Finance is the authority for the enforcement of FEMA.

Q 94. C **Major Completed Road Projects in India:**

- **Atal Tunnel: World's Longest Highway Tunnel above 10,000 Feet,** Atal Tunnel was inaugurated by Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi on October 3, 2020. The tunnel reduces the road distance by 46 Kms between Manali and Leh and the time by about 4 to 5 hours.
- **Dhola-Sadia Bridge: In May 2017, Dhola-Sadiya Bridge in Assam was inaugurated by Prime Minister** to connect far-off areas and pave the way for their socio-economic development. **It is India's longest bridge, with a length of 9.15 km. Hence, pair 1 is correctly matched.**
- **Chenani-Nashri tunnel:** The tunnel in Jammu and Kashmir was opened in 2017. The 9 km long, all-weather tunnel between Udhampur and Ramban in Jammu & Kashmir is not only India's longest highway tunnel under operation but also **Asia's longest bi-directional highway tunnel, which is equipped with Integrated Tunnel Control System (ITCS). Hence, pair 2 is correctly matched.**
- **Maitri Setu:** Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi inaugurated 'Maitri Setu' between India and Bangladesh through video conferencing on March 9, 2021. Also called the 'Gateway of North East', the crucial bridge built over the Feni River to link with Tripura with Chittagong in Bangladesh is 1.9 km long, built at a cost of Rs. 133 crore.
- **Sudarshan Setu (Beyt Dwarka):** Hon'ble Prime Minister inaugurated Sudarshan Setu on February 25, 2024 which connects Okha mainland and Beyt Dwarka island, built at a cost of around Rs. 980 crores. **It is the longest Cable-stayed bridge in the country of around 2.32 km. Hence, pair 3 is correctly matched.**
- **Sonamarg Tunnel (Z-Morh):** Sonamarg Tunnel of length 6.4 km on NH-01 in the UT of Jammu &Kashmir was inaugurated by Prime Minister on January 13, 2025. Situated at an altitude of

over 8,650 ft. above sea level, it will enhance all-weather connectivity between Srinagar and Sonamarg enroute to Leh.

Q 95. D

- **In WTO terminology, subsidies in general are identified by "boxes" which are given the colours of traffic lights: green (permitted), amber (slow down — i.e. need to be reduced), red (forbidden). In agriculture, things are, as usual, more complicated.** The Agreement on Agriculture has no red box, although domestic support exceeding the reduction commitment levels in the amber box is prohibited; and there is a blue box for subsidies that are tied to programmes that limit production.
- **Amber Box:** Nearly all domestic support measures considered to distort production and trade (with some exceptions) fall into the amber box. These include measures to support prices, or subsidies directly related to production quantities. **Hence statement 2 is not correct.**

  Green Box: The green box is defined in Annex 2 of the Agreement on Agriculture.
  - In order to qualify, green box subsidies must not distort trade, or at most cause minimal distortion.
  - They have to be government-funded (not by charging consumers higher prices) and must not involve price support.
  - They tend to be programmes that are not targeted at particular products, and include **direct income supports for farmers that are not related to (are "decoupled" from) current production levels or prices. Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
  - They also include environmental protection and regional development programmes.
  - Green box subsidies are therefore **allowed without limits, provided they comply with the policy-specific criteria.** India's Public distribution system does not come under the Green Box.
- **Blue Box:** This is the "amber box with conditions" — conditions designed to reduce distortion. Any support that would normally be in the amber box, is placed in the blue box if the support also requires farmers to limit production. At present there are no limits on spending on blue box subsidies.

Q 96. C

- **India now holds the second-largest number of active trademark registrations in the world,** with over 3.2 million trademarks in force. This indicates a highly active and competitive domestic marketplace, where businesses are not only creating new products but also working diligently to protect their brand identities.
- **The largest proportion of trademark filings in India came from sectors such as Health (21.9%), Agriculture (15.3%), and Clothing (12.8%).** These figures highlight India's leadership in areas such as pharmaceuticals, food production, and fashion. As global demand for Indian products continues to rise, the importance of trademark filings as a tool for safeguarding brand equity becomes ever more critical, ensuring that Indian products and services maintain their competitive edge in international markets. **Hence, option (c) is the correct answer.**

Q 97. A

- **Context**: One of the most consequential reforms introduced through India's new Labour Codes is the standardised definition of "wages". This definition directly affects the computation of social security benefits such as Provident Fund, gratuity, bonus, and other statutory contributions. The reform aims to curb the long-standing practice of splitting salaries into multiple allowances to reduce employers' statutory liabilities.

What Constitutes "Wages" under the New Labour Codes

Under all four Labour Codes, "wages" have been given a uniform definition. At the core, wages consist of:

- Basic Pay. **Hence option 1 is correct.**
- Dearness Allowance (DA). **Hence option 2 is correct.**
- Retaining Allowance, wherever applicable

- **Bonus and overtime allowance are excluded from the definition of wages. Hence options 3 and 4 are not correct.**
- These components form the fixed and regular remuneration paid to an employee and are mandatorily included for calculating statutory benefits.

Treatment of Allowances and the 50% Rule

The Labour Codes introduce a crucial 50% ceiling rule:

- Allowances such as performance-linked incentives, bonuses, HRA, overtime, commissions, etc., are excluded from wages, provided their total does not exceed 50% of total remuneration.
- This allows flexibility while preventing artificial lowering of the wage base.

Add-back Mechanism and Its Legal Effect

If the total value of excluded components exceeds 50% of total remuneration, the excess amount:

- Is added back to wages, and
- Is treated as wages itself, not as a separate allowance.

- This add-back amount becomes fully liable for PF, gratuity, and other wage-linked benefits.

Q 98. D In agriculture, there are different prices, like

- **Minimum Support Price:** A price floor set by the government for specific crops to safeguard farmers from sharp price declines, ensuring they get a remunerative price even during bumper harvests.
- **Procurement Price:** A Procurement Price (PP) is the rate at which a government buys agricultural produce, like food grains, from farmers to build buffer stocks and supply the Public Distribution System (PDS), often set after harvest, usually above the Minimum Support Price (MSP) but below open market rates, serving to support farmers and ensure food security.
- **Issue Price:** The Issue Price is the subsidized rate at which the government sells food grains (like wheat and rice) to the poor and vulnerable through the Public Distribution System (PDS) via Fair Price Shops, significantly lower than market or procurement prices, acting as a food subsidy to ensure affordability for the needy.

- **Hence, option (d) is the correct answer.**

Q 99. B
- **Recent Context:** Indian Coast Guard Ships (ICGS) Samudra Pratap, India's first indigenously designed Pollution Control Vessel (PCV), was commissioned in Goa.

ICGS Samudra Pratap

- **It is the first of two PCVs being built by Goa Shipyard Limited (GSL).**
- Largest ship in the Indian Coast Guard (ICG) fleet.
- It is equipped with advanced pollution detection systems, dedicated pollution response boats, a pollution control laboratory, and modern firefighting capabilities.

- **Hence, option (b) is the correct answer.**

Q 100. C

- **Recent Context:** On January 14, 2026, the coolest library on Earth was inaugurated at the Concordia station, Antarctica

  The ice coring technique involves drilling cylindrical cores from ice sheets and glaciers (such as in Antarctica, Greenland, or high-altitude glaciers). These ice cores preserve:
  - Layered snowfall records over thousands of years,
  - Air bubbles trapped in ice that reveal past atmospheric composition (CO_2, methane, etc.), and
  - Dust and volcanic ash layers indicating past climatic and volcanic events.
- **This makes ice coring a crucial tool for reconstructing Earth's past climate and understanding natural climate variability before human influence. Hence, option (c) is the correct answer.**